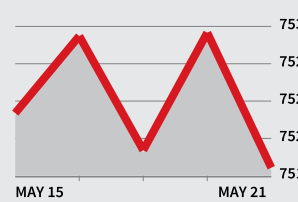


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 75183.36 (-135.03)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23654.70	-4.30
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.29	-0.04
US Dollar (in ₹)	96.20	-0.62
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	157903.00	-17
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	264679.00	-2623

FEARS EXAGGERATED.

Kearney's chief Bob Willen

downplays rupee concerns, highlighting the country's growth trajectory **p8**



SLOWING GROWTH.

ITC fourth quarter profit up 5%;
GST rate increase and West Asia
conflict impact margins **p2**

QUICKLY.

EXPANSION AND REJIG
TVK government in TN
inducts 23 Ministers



Chennai: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Thursday expanded his Cabinet with the induction of 23 members into the Council of Ministers, including two legislators from the Indian National Congress and 21 members from his party Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK). This takes the total size of the Ministry to 33, including Vijay, who has multiple portfolios under him. **p13**

BONUS BOOST
LIC Q4 net profit surges
23% to ₹23,467 crore

Mumbai: The Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) has registered a 23 per cent increase in net profit in the March quarter at ₹23,467 crore against ₹19,039 crore logged in the same period last year. The insurance behemoth has also announced a 1-for-1 bonus issue of shares, as well as a pre-bonus dividend of ₹10 per share. **p8**

Labour Code reset triggers take-home salary concerns

NEED FOR CLARITY. Experts say communication is vital for managing staff perceptions

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

As companies begin to align employee pay structures with the new Labour Codes, the impact on take-home pay is emerging as the biggest discussion point within India Inc, more so in the appraisal season. Companies are realising that clear communication will be the key determinant of how employees perceive the transition.

The primary change in the new code is the definition of 'wage', an equivalent of the erstwhile 'basic' pay. While most companies kept the proportion of basic component lower, it now needs to be 50 per cent of total pay.

This means PF and other statutory deductions, calculated on this base, will now be higher, leading to marginally lower take home pay, depending on the tax slab and other considerations.

HIGHER ACCRUALS
However, long-term social security benefits improve due to higher accruals.

Radhika Viswanathan, Executive Director, Deloitte In-

PAY STRUCTURE

- The basic pay should now be 50% of the total pay
- This leads to higher PF and other statutory deductions
- Employers are not likely to increase the CTC to offset this
- Boost in long-term service benefits; monthly net pay to be lower



dia, said companies are mindful of the potential impact on take-home pay and are running detailed scenario analyses to identify where take-home pay could be affected and how they can legally mitigate that.

PF DEDUCTIONS

For instance, the new Labour Codes do not reduce take-home pay if companies have been calculating PF deductions on statutory wage ceiling of ₹15,000. Anything beyond this limit is voluntary, not mandatory, she noted.

"We are seeing uneven but definite on-ground movement on Labour Code compliance," Srinivasa Bharathy,

MD and CEO, Adrenalin eSystems, which makes software for Labour Code-led restructuring, said.

Some enterprises are aligning wage restructuring with appraisal cycles, while others remain cautious due to CHRO-CFO alignment and other reasons, he added.

For instance, the HR of a Chennai-based mid-size IT company said that they are awaiting final notification of the State rules to implement the restructuring.

Malathi KS, Director, Rewards Consulting, Products and Global Mobility Practice, Mercer India, said that large listed companies have either already implemented

Adani Group firms set to acquire Jaiprakash assets for ₹5,694 cr

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad



Jaiprakash Power Ventures Ltd (JPVL) held by JAL, along with a business transfer agreement for the acquisition of JAL's 180 MW thermal power plant located in Churk, Uttar Pradesh, and related assets, including a 11.49 per cent stake in Prayagraj Power Generation Company Ltd.

Adani Power had informed the exchanges on March 19, 2026, that it had expressed in-principle interest in becoming one of the implementing entities under the resolution plan submitted by Adani Enterprises Ltd for buying certain power assets and investments of JAL.

STAKE BUYING

The acquisition of the 24 per cent stake in JPVL will cost Adani Power about ₹2,993.59 crore, while the acquisition of the Churk thermal power plant and related assets, including the stake in Prayagraj Power Generation Company, will cost ₹1,200 crore. The total transaction value stands at nearly ₹4,194 crore.

Jaiprakash Associates, in a separate filing, said a monitoring committee had been constituted to manage the affairs of the corporate debtor and supervise implementation of the approved resolution plan.

Following Adani Enterprises Ltd emerging as the successful resolution applicant for Jaiprakash Associates Ltd under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), Adani Group firms — Adani Power and Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd (APSEZ) — have begun executing the acquisition of Jaiprakash assets through transactions worth nearly ₹5,694 crore, spanning power generation, logistics and strategic land parcels.

Adani Power on Thursday said it will invest around ₹4,194 crore to acquire a 24 per cent stake in Jaiprakash Power Ventures Ltd (JPVL), the 180 MW Churk thermal power plant in Uttar Pradesh, and related assets, including a 11.49 per cent stake in Prayagraj Power Generation Company Ltd.

Separately, APSEZ, in a regulatory filing, said it had signed a share purchase agreement with Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL) to acquire 100 per cent shareholding of Jaypee Fertilizers & Industries Ltd (JFIL) for ₹1,500 crore.

JFIL is the holding company of Kanpur Fertilizers

or are doing final checks. IT/BPO/start-ups are still in the awareness stage, and mid-market and SMEs are largely unaware, she added.

"The practical advice we give clients — do not wait for your State rules to start the CTC financial modelling," she said.

A clear and structured communication to employees is key, experts noted.

Amit Kumar Otewani, Associate Partner, Talent Solutions, India, Aon, said that a practice companies could follow is "before-and-after salary statements", that compare old basic versus revised basic, PF contribution impact, gratuity accruals and revised net pay, he said.

For instance, gratuity, which was included within the CTC earlier, has to be shown separately now, out of the total pay.

CONFUSION PREVAILS

As TCS rolled out its new pay structures recently, this exclusion led to widespread confusion among its staff. The IT major is now sending e-mailers and elaborate FAQs on the Labour Code changes.

India joins forces with China, South Korea and Japan against UK steel curbs at WTO

Amiti Sen
New Delhi



India has joined major steel-exporting nations, including Japan, South Korea and China, at the World Trade Organization (WTO) to protest against a UK proposal that would slash tariff-free steel import quotas from July 1 and increase duties on shipments exceeding the quota to 50 per cent, sources said.

New Delhi's objections, raised at a WTO Goods Council meeting on Wednesday, are in sync with its attempts to bilaterally resolve the dispute with the UK by stalling operationalisation of the India-UK FTA till a solution is found.

"Japan and Korea introduced the item underlining their reservations with the UK's steel safeguard measures to be implemented from July 1, 2026. Countries including India, China, Brazil, Australia, Switzerland and Türkiye supported them," a Geneva-based trade official told *businessline*.

The complainants argued that concerns on global steel overcapacity should not be

addressed through import restrictions but by addressing root causes. They also questioned the consistency of such measures with WTO rules.

NEW MEASURE

New Delhi is trying to convince the UK to sort out the matter bilaterally as the new measure was not accounted for in the India-UK comprehensive economic and trade agreement (CETA) talks that concluded in July 2025.

India was promised tariff elimination on 99 per cent of goods by the UK, but the steel measure would impose additional burden.

India's export of iron and steel to the UK in FY26 was around \$900 million, much of which could be hit by UK's

new steel safeguard measures. "We are working together to find a creative solution around the steel measure and operationalise the CETA at an early date," Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal told reporters last week when asked about the delay in operationalisation of the free trade pact.

In its defence, the UK noted at the WTO that the new steel measures were legitimate and necessary to protect its steel making capability, the source said.

The creative solution being examined by India and the UK bilaterally to break the FTA deadlock could be centred on creating an India-specific quota within the UK's new framework, an industry source said.

Furry evacuees of Gulf conflict land safely in India

Data show that 181 dogs and 95 cats were flown in from the region in March

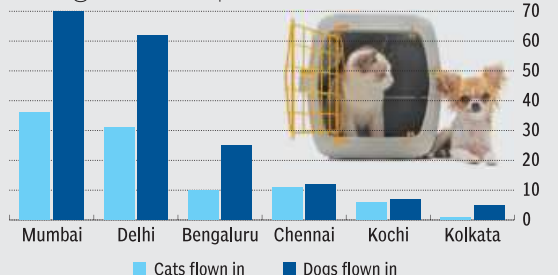
Anees Phadnis
Mumbai

Dubai resident Chashmi Aggarwal spent anxious moments before her Emirates flight took off for Delhi on the night of March 12.

Dubai had come under Iranian drone attack earlier, and Aggarwal, who was travelling with her three-year-old Maltese dog 'Nova', was anxious. What if the airport is attacked? Would Nova be evacuated from the aircraft's cargo hold was her worry, she says, reflecting on those fraught days. "Thankfully everything went smoothly," she says.

Nova was among the 292 pets that flew into India from the Gulf region in March, data obtained from the Animal Quarantine and Certification Services (AQCS) under the Right to Information Act show. This

The great escape



Source: Animal Quarantine and Certification Service

included 181 dogs and 95 cats, the vast majority transported from the UAE.

Mumbai and Delhi airports saw the highest arrival of pets from the Gulf region in March — 106 and 93 — respectively. Kolkata saw the fewest — six — due to limited air connectivity with the Gulf region.

"During the height of the conflict in March, we received around 100 calls daily from pet parents from

the Gulf region. Families wanted to travel to India but weren't sure whether they would be able to carry their pets. Flight schedules were also changing frequently due to airspace closures," said Anand Vishwanath, Managing Partner of relocation service provider Furry Flyers.

"We helped around 15 families from the UAE, Bahrain and Qatar to travel with their pets. There was a

sense of panic among pet parents in March but the situation is stable now," added Varun Nandwani of KL Bhrara & Co, a pet relocation service firm.

In fact, some pet parents have returned to Dubai and other Gulf countries with their furry friends.

RELAXED NORMS

Government norms require a pet to be vaccinated (30 days prior to travel), micro-chipped and checked by a doctor before its import. A certificate from the local government department is also mandatory for obtaining a no-objection certificate from the Indian government. On March 12, the Department of Animal Husbandry and Dairying issued a memorandum relaxing some of these requirements for Indians stranded in the Gulf region as a one-time relaxation.

A Monk Who Trades



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QUICKLY.

Honasa Consumer Q4 net profit up at ₹69 crore

New Delhi: Honasa Consumer, known for brands such as Mamaearth and Aqualogica, posted a consolidated net profit of ₹69.4 crore in the March quarter, up about 178 per cent over ₹25 crore in the year-ago quarter. Consolidated revenue from operations stood at ₹657.08 crore, up 23.15 per cent. The company's board approved its maiden final dividend of ₹3 per equity share. **OUR BUREAU**

VA Tech Wabag Q4 PAT up 28.6% to ₹128 crore

Chennai: Water technology company VA Tech Wabag reported a 28.6 per cent growth in consolidated net profit for Q4 FY26 at ₹128 crore. Revenue from operations grew 24 per cent to ₹1,446 crore. For FY26, consolidated revenue from operations stood at ₹3,401 crore, while consolidated PAT was ₹334 crore. The board recommended a dividend of ₹5 per fully paid-up share. **OUR BUREAU**

CPCL launches first CoCo fuel station near Manali refinery

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

Chennai Petroleum Corporation Ltd (CPCL), an arm of Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), on Wednesday launched its first company-owned company-operated (CoCo) retail fuel outlet — under the brand name Sooper — near its Manali refinery in North Chennai. This marks the refiner's renewed entry into fuel retailing after nearly two decades, with plans for retail outlets across India in phases. In April, CPCL launched its first dealer-operated retail outlet Nemam in Tiruvallur district, Tamil Nadu. The latest CoCo outlet at Mathur on Ennore

ITC Q4 profit up 5%, GST rate hike and W. Asia war impact margins

KEY DRIVERS. Revenue boosted by strong cigarette and non-cigarette FMCG businesses

Our Bureau
Kolkata

Broadly in line with street estimates, diversified conglomerate ITC reported a 4.89 per cent year-on-year increase in its standalone net profit in Q4FY26 to ₹5,113.36 crore, as increased GST rate along with a steep hike in excise duties, and West Asia conflict impacted profitability of its cigarette and agri-business segments, respectively.

The Kolkata-headquartered conglomerate had posted a net profit of ₹4,874.93 crore in Q4FY25 on the basis of continued operations. Notably, the conglomerate's hotel business was demerged into ITC Hotels effective January 1, 2025.

Revenue from operations during Q4 grew 17.30 per cent year on year to ₹21,694.67 crore (₹18,494.55 crore), backed by strong performances

Scorecard (in ₹ crore)			
	Q4FY25	Q4FY26	Change (%)
Revenue from operations	18,494.5	21,694.7	17.3
Total expenses	12,872.9	15,655.6	21.6
Tax expenses	1,542.1	1,580.6	2.5
Net profit	4,874.9	5,113.4	4.9

from cigarette and non-cigarette FMCG segments.

ITC, in a statement, said it posted a strong performance during Q4FY26 amid supply chain disruptions and logistical challenges due to the ongoing West Asia conflict. Overall EBITDA grew 7.3 per cent.

CIGARETTE BIZ

Revenue from its cigarettes business rose 31.74 per cent to ₹11,066.02 crore in Q4, while operating profit from the segment increased 7.23 per cent y to ₹5,488.16 crore, according to the stock exchange filing.

The country's largest cigarette maker said an increase in GST rate from 28

per cent of transaction value to 40 per cent of retail sale price along with a steep hike in excise duties effective February 1, 2026, upon phasing out of Compensation Cess, resulted in an unprecedented increase in tax incidence on cigarettes.

NON-CIGARETTE FMCG

During Q4, the non-cigarette FMCG business registered a 14.72 per cent growth in revenue to ₹6,303.73 crore, while the segment posted a 50.98 per cent increase in operating profit to ₹520.74 crore. The segment's EBITDA margin was up around 200 basis points to 11 per cent (excluding 24 Mantra Organic). Notably, the non-cigarette

FMCG business' contribution to the conglomerate's gross revenue stood at 29.37 per cent (30.08 per cent). This segment's contribution to profit before tax rose to 7.78 per cent (5.37 per cent).

AGRI AND PAPER BIZ

The company's agri business witnessed a 15.74 per cent fall in revenue to ₹3,074.86 crore, whereas the segment registered a 29.63 per cent decline in operating profit to ₹179.48 crore. The performance was hit due to deferral of sales amid the West Asia conflict.

The paperboards, paper & packaging business of the conglomerate witnessed a 1.82 per cent growth in revenue to ₹2,227.52 crore. The business posted a 21.22 per cent increase in its operating profit to ₹245.15 crore.

ITC's board recommended a final dividend of ₹8 per share. Total dividend for FY26 amounted to ₹14.50 per share.

‘Q-comm firms spend ₹98-100 per order despite increasing dark stores’

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Profitability in the quick commerce (q-comm) industry is set to be under pressure for a longer duration with players spending a minimum of around ₹98-100 to service each order, a recent report by Bernstein has found.

DATA FOCUS.

Competition among q-comm players is not likely to ease soon, and 2027 will see continued competitive intensity as all players target the same customers in the same cities, it adds.

The current fulfilment costs of Blinkit and Instamart (the listed players) is around ₹116-118 per order and even with all efficiency levers such as increasing the orders per rider per day and batching the orders, the costs may only fall to around ₹98-100 per order, Bernstein estimates.

Long-term profitability must thus come from higher basket values, more advertising revenue and higher-margin non-grocery products, the research firm points out.

As for the strategy of various q-comm players, the report notes that Zepto has adopted a different strategy from rivals like Swiggy's Instamart and Eternal's Blinkit.

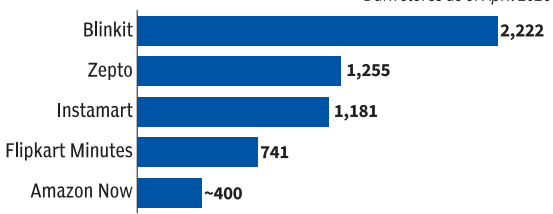
DARK STORES

Zepto is leveraging dark-store density and aggressive discounting to drive repeat purchases from existing users, rather than chasing new users, thus aiming at lower costs. Dark stores refers to the small-size stores that pack the products for the delivery partners to deliver.

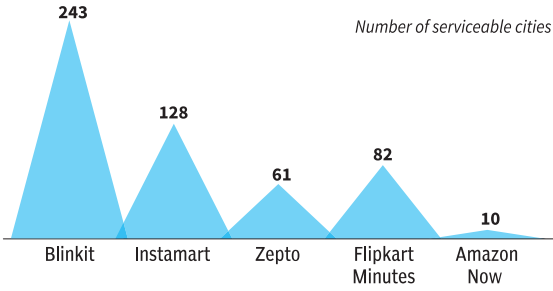
Bernstein's analysis showed that Zepto has around 1,255 dark stores, second only to Blinkit's 2,222, as of April 2026. But Zepto's stores are concen-

Quick commerce race

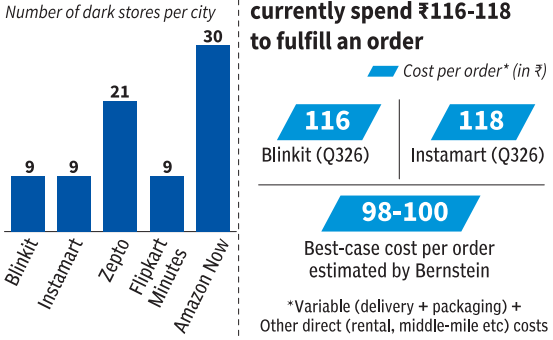
Blinkit has the largest network of dark stores, Zepto in second spot



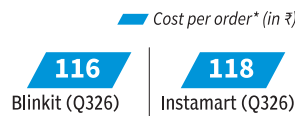
While Blinkit and Instamart have expanded across cities, Zepto's focus is on large cities



Zepto has more stores per city



Despite large store network, Blinkit and Instamart currently spend ₹116-118 to fulfill an order



98-100

Best-case cost per order estimated by Bernstein

*Variable (delivery + packaging) + Other direct (rental, middle-mile etc) costs

Source: Bernstein Dark store database, Company reports

trated in only 61 cities, versus 243 for Blinkit and 128 for Instamart. Thus, Zepto averages around 21 stores per city, double that of its peers.

This density allows for shorter delivery distances, faster delivery and lower rider costs, Bernstein says.

ACTIVE USER BASE

Similarly, the monthly active user base of the apps also throws up interesting findings.

After increasing across 2024 and 2025, Zepto's monthly active users (MAU) ended at around 58 million, as of March 2026, after see-

ing a peak of 60 million in August 2025.

Blinkit, on the other hand, has continued its rise from roughly 55 million in July 2025 to 77 million in March 2026.

Instamart's MAUs are at around 20 million, but this reflects only the standalone Instamart app, and Instamart is also accessed from within the main Swiggy super-app.

However, when one looks at sessions per week, Zepto's user engagement has gone up from 7.5 sessions/user/week in August 2025 to 10.5 by March 2026, the highest in the industry.

Maruti hikes prices by up to ₹30,000 across models, effective June, due to high input costs

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

India's largest passenger vehicle manufacturer Maruti Suzuki India (MSIL) on Thursday announced a price hike of up to ₹30,000 across its model range, effective June. The automaker attributed the upward price revision to persistently-elevated inflationary pressures and an ongoing adverse cost environment that continues to impact its operations.

MSIL is among the last original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) to announce a price hike this year. Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Motors, JSW MG Motor, and Kia India have already implemented price hikes of up to 3 per cent from April 1, due to high input costs, while Hy-

undai Motor India increased prices by up to 1 per cent across its portfolio, effective May.

"In view of the sustained increase in input costs, the company has decided to increase the prices of its models across its portfolio by up to ₹30,000 with effect from June," MSIL said.

COST IMPACT

It said for the past few months, the company has been making continuous efforts to mitigate the cost impact to the extent possible through cost reduction measures.

"However, with inflationary pressures now at elevated levels and the adverse cost environment persisting, the company has to pass on a portion of the increased costs to the market, while



continuing to ensure that the impact on customers is kept to the minimum extent possible," it said, adding that the exact quantum of change will vary from model to model.

According to the OEMs, the persistent global supply-chain disruptions and foreign exchange fluctuations due to geopolitical tensions have necessitated the price hikes over the last few months, not only by mass-market vehicle makers, but also by luxury carmakers such as BMW, Mercedes-Benz and Volvo.

BMW Group India and Mercedes-Benz India have

already indicated another price hike in the coming months. BMW Group India has already hiked prices effective April 1 by up to 2 per cent across its BMW and Mini range. This was the second price hike this calendar year.

"We will take another price rise, anywhere between 2 per cent and 3 per cent, because of the current forex situation. This price rise is expected anytime soon," Hardeep Singh Brar, President and CEO, BMW Group India, said recently.

Similarly, Mercedes-Benz India, MD and CEO, Santosh Iyer, said recently that the company was planning a third price hike from July because of supply chain delays and management, and significant deterioration in exchange rates.

LG Electronics India Q4 net profit dips 8.1% to ₹693 crore despite highest quarterly revenue

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Higher commodity costs and a depreciating rupee impacted LG Electronics India's profits in the March quarter. The company posted a net profit of ₹692.7 crore for the quarter, down 8.19 per cent from ₹754.5 crore in the corresponding quarter of FY25. However, revenue from operations grew 8.1 per cent to ₹8,053.55 crore.

Hong Ju Jeon, Managing Director, LG Electronics India, said, "LG Electronics India has delivered its highest-ever quarterly revenue in Q4 FY26. We are navigating macro challenges in complex global environment with calibrated actions and continued investment in

Q4 performance (in ₹ crore)			
	Q4FY25	Q4FY26	Change (%)
Net profit	754.54	692.7	-8.19
Revenue from operations	7,448.42	8,053.55	8.12

premiumisation."

Sanjay Chitkara, Director and Co-CSMO, told *businessline*, "We sold over one million units of air-conditioners (ACs) in the March quarter. Our home entertainment segment has garnered nearly 20 per cent growth, driven by the premiumisation focus and also aided by GST rationalisation. Our three strategic pillars of Make in India, Make for India and Make India Global enabled us to garner highest-ever quarterly revenue."

KEY CHALLENGES

Atul Khanna, Chief Account-

ing Officer, said that the year-on-year EBITDA margins were affected due to impact of commodity prices and fluctuations in the currency movement. "However, we remain optimistic on margin improvement while maintaining focus on cost discipline, localisation and operational efficiency. We would also be targeting to increase our exports significantly, and it will give us a buffer coverage for hedging currency fluctuation impact. Currently, exports contribute about 6 per cent to our revenues," he added.

On the impact of the West

Asia conflict, Chitkara said, "The Summer season demand trends are strong, as the penetration level of ACs is very low in India. We are optimistic that we will garner a good growth in the ongoing quarter. We have made some price adjustments to mitigate cost pressures and have taken a price hike in April. We remain watchful of the situation."

"The recent developments regarding import restrictions on compressors will have absolutely no impact on our AC and refrigerator business operations. We have in-house manufacturing capacity of compressors for refrigerators and ACs, and have other local arrangements. In fact, we are increasing compressor manufacturing capacity for ACs," Chitkara stated.

Forgive the burn, focus on the gigafactory, says Ola's Bhavish Aggarwal

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

In his May 20 letter to shareholders, Bhavish Aggarwal, Chairman and Managing Director, Ola Electric Mobility, made an implicit bargain: Judge Ola Electric less by the hole burned in its balance sheet and more by the factories, technology and battery platform that shareholder capital has helped create.

"FY26 was a year of reset for Ola Electric," Aggarwal wrote. The message is clear.

Aggarwal is asking shareholders to look past a bruising year in scooters and focus on what he believes is the company's more enduring asset: A vertically-integrated battery and energy platform that could eventually matter more than the vehicles that financed it.

Whether that bet justifies the pain endured by customers and investors remains to

be seen. But Aggarwal wants investors to remember FY26 less as the year Ola Electric lost its lead in electric scooters and more as the year it laid the industrial foundations for a business far larger than scooters.

CONCISE ADMISSION

Aggarwal stops short of offering a direct apology to customers or shareholders. Instead, he acknowledges that service had become "the largest constraint on demand and brand trust," a concise admission of the operational failures that hurt both customer confidence and Ola's market position.

FY26 was when customers and investors bore the cost of execution lapses. Sales fell sharply, market share slipped and thousands of owners grappled with service delays and quality issues that dented confidence in one of India's most high-profile EV brands.

Aggarwal's argument is that these setbacks should be viewed not merely as operational mistakes, but as the construction cost of a much larger energy business. That understated phrase captures the heart of Ola's problem. Service delays stretched to around nine days in October 2025, and backlogs reached 14 days before improving to nearly one day by March 2026. For thousands of customers, those delays turned what was marketed as a technology-led mobility revolution into a frustrating ownership experience.

The financial toll was equally revealing. Warranty costs fell to ₹59 crore (₹555 crore) in FY26. Part of that decline reflects lower sales, but the reduction was far steeper than the 43.5 per cent drop in deliveries to 173,794 units (307,846). Had Ola incurred warranty costs at the same per-vehicle rate as FY25, the FY26 warranty



Bhavish Aggarwal, Chairman and MD, Ola Electric

bill would have been roughly ₹313 crore, indicating a substantial improvement in product quality and repair efficiency. Evidence that the reset is working.

THE REAL PITCH

The strongest part of Aggarwal's letter lies in batteries. "Ola was built for this moment," he wrote, arguing that the company is uniquely positioned across "the two most important pillars of India's energy future, electric mobility and batteries."

Ola has said its Gigafactory has 2.5 GWh of opera-

tional capacity, with installation for a 6-GWh commercial ramp largely complete and expected to be fully commercialised by the current quarter-end. "This is no longer a conceptual project but an operating manufacturing platform running at commercially-viable yields," the company said in its investor presentation.

According to the management, the sleeper detail in the presentation is Ola's claim to have commercialised dry-electrode manufacturing technology, which can reduce capex by 33 per cent, lower energy consumption by 40-60 per cent and shrink factory footprint by 70 per cent compared with conventional processes.

About 15 per cent of current vehicle orders already use Ola-made cells, and the company expects its entire product portfolio to transition to in-house batteries by September 2026. Beyond

vehicles, Ola has launched Shakti, a distributed energy-storage product with more than 50,000 leads and over 200 distributor partners, and is developing Mahashakti, a utility-scale storage system targeted for launch in CY27. Ola estimates India's battery market could reach 420 GWh annually by 2035, representing a roughly \$30-billion opportunity. It plans to expand its battery capacity from 6 GWh to 20 GWh through a capital raise at the cell subsidiary level, a move that suggests the battery business could eventually attract standalone funding — and perhaps a valuation separate from the loss-making vehicle business.

The scooters tested the patience of customers and scorched investor confidence. Aggarwal is now asking shareholders to place one more bet — that the Gigafactory, not the scooters, will ultimately deliver the payoff.

Aurobindo Pharma's Q4 profit up 2% to ₹921 crore

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Aurobindo Pharma's consolidated net profit increased 2 per cent to ₹921 crore in Q4 FY26 compared to ₹903 crore in the year-ago period. The total revenue of the Hyderabad-based company grew 5.6 per cent to ₹8,853 crore (₹8,382 crore).

For FY26, net profit almost remained flat at ₹3,503 crore (₹3,484 crore), while the total revenue increased 6.1 per cent to ₹33,653 crore (₹31,724 crore).

K Nithyananda Reddy, Vice-Chairman and Managing Director, Aurobindo Pharma, said, "With ongoing investments in capacity expansion and the stabilisation of recently-commercialised facilities, we remain confident in our ability to support sustainable growth and cre-

ate long-term value for our stakeholders."

US REVENUE DIPS

The US revenue decreased 13 per cent to ₹3,543 crore, primarily due to lower transient sales and accounted for 40 per cent of consolidated revenue.

The revenue from Europe increased 30 per cent to ₹2,795 crore, driven by robust performance across all key markets; and accounted for 31.6 per cent of consolidated revenue.

businessline.

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QUICKLY.

‘Oil market could hit red zone in July-August’



London: The start of peak summer fuel demand, combined with the lack of new oil exports from West Asia and depleting stocks, could push the oil market into the “red zone” in July-August, the head of the International Energy Agency said on Thursday. The world entered the oil supply crisis caused by the Iran war with a surplus of oil, which helped to absorb the shock, but now stocks are now eroding, Fatih Birol said. REUTERS

PFRDA panel to look at induction of asset classes

New Delhi: The Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) has set up a panel to look into the long-term induction of different asset classes for improving returns for pensioners. “We have to look at new assets which can provide continuous and steady growth over a long period of time without volatility... We cannot show a very high return in one year and after that, it drops off. That volatility we need to avoid,” PFRDA Chairman S Ramann said. PTI

‘US firms committed over \$60 b investments in the last 6 months’

RENEWED PUSH. Upcoming visit by Rubio is a testament to the deepening India-US ties, says Piyush Goyal

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal on Thursday said India has received investment commitments in data centres, semiconductor plants and factories from American companies to the tune of \$60 billion in the last six months.

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters, Goyal said the upcoming visit of the US Secretary of State Marco Rubio is a testament to this growing partnership between the two countries.

“The visit of the Secretary of State Marco Rubio is extremely timely, it reflects the growing partnership between the US and India which will provide newer and bigger opportunities to our youth, to our farmers, to our women, entrepreneurs, start-ups, industries, open up huge investment opportunities in India for US capital. In fact, in the last six months alone, we have heard big announcements aggregating to more than \$60 billion. Imagine, 6 lakh crore investment is coming



ALL SET FOR TRADE TALKS. Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal addressing the AMCHAM Annual Leadership Summit in New Delhi on Thursday. AMCHAM Chairman and IBM Managing Director Sandip Patel and Boeing India and South Asia President Salil Gupta are also present ANI

to India in data centres, in factories, semiconductor plants. US alone has made these investments. That is why we are called the ‘trusted partner’ in the world,” the Minister said.

If the commitment of \$60 billion in just six months actually materialises, it would reflect the pattern of increase in the FDI inflows from the US into India.

Government data show that FDI inflows from the US have seen a steady rise — from \$36.05 billion in FY 2013-14 to \$81.04 billion in FY 2024-25.

RUBIO'S VISIT

Rubio will undertake a four-day visit to India beginning May 23 to further coopera-

tion between the two countries.

Goyal highlighted new technologies as the thrust area where India and the US are collaborating.

“We have a strategic partnership in minerals, we are working together in new technologies like Artificial intelligence, quantum computing, machine learning. We are co-designing and co-producing technologies of the future,” he said.

On whether Rubio's visit reflects a renewed push for the India-US bilateral trade agreement which is yet to be signed, Goyal said: “We have finalised an interim, phase 1 of a bilateral trade agreement whereby India will get preferential access to the

large \$30 trillion US market. We have millions of Indians living and working in the US. They are our bridge to the US. Our Prime Minister is often called by the US President his one true friend.”

US TEAM COMING

At another event in Delhi, Goyal said a US team is likely to visit India next month for trade talks with their counterparts here.

The Indian side visited Washington, DC, in April for an in-person round of meetings with their US counterparts to finalise the details of the interim pact and take forward the negotiations under the broader bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

When asked if the US chief

negotiator for the BTA will accompany Rubio, Goyal said, “He’s not coming with him, but there is some plan for them to come next month”.

TRADE PACT

Meanwhile, addressing the annual leadership summit of AMCHAM India in New Delhi, US Ambassador to India said Sergio Gor said Indian firms are steadily expanding their business footprint across the American market.

“I was thrilled to see Indian companies committing more than \$20 billion in investments in the US at the annual Select Investment Summit,” he said.

Speaking about the trade negotiations between the two countries, Gor said the interim trade agreement between India and the US is in the final stages of discussions.

“President Trump’s goal is to facilitate bilateral trade in a way that creates lucrative opportunities for American businesses and workers. Our current interim trade agreement is on the table to be finalised, unlocking prosperity for both nations,” he said.

GAIL’s Q4 net falls 41% due to disruption in LNG supplies

Scorecard (in ₹ cr)			
	Q4 FY25	Q3 FY26	Q4 FY26
Total income	36,944	35,641	36,497
Net profit	2,506	1,729	1,482
Total expenses	33,983	33,822	34,989

Source: Company

Our Bureau
New Delhi

State-run GAIL (India) on Thursday reported a 41 per cent y-o-y decline in its consolidated net profit at around ₹1,481 crore in Q4 FY26 on account of the loss of LNG supplies due to the conflict in West Asia.

On a sequential basis, net profit of the country’s largest gas utility fell by 14 per cent.

GAIL’s consolidated total income during the March quarter in FY26 stood at around ₹36,497 crore compared to ₹35,641 crore in Q3 FY26 and ₹36,944 crore in Q4 FY25.

Total expenses on a consolidated basis were higher at ₹34,989 crore in Q4 FY26, compared to ₹33,822 crore in Q3 FY26 and ₹33,983 crore in Q4 FY25.

FINAL DIVIDEND

The board of directors has recommended a final dividend of ₹0.50 per equity share for FY26, subject to shareholder approval. This is in addition to the interim dividend of ₹5 per share, taking

the total dividend payout ratio for the year to 51.90 per cent.

On the West Asia situation, GAIL, in its results filing with the BSE, said, “During March, LNG supplies from the Middle East were disrupted due to the geopolitical situation in West Asia. Further, *force majeure* declared by Petronet LNG (PLL) on March 3, 2026, RLNG allocation to the company under the contract was reduced to zero from March 4, 2026, and four LNG cargoes under other contracts were also impacted.”

This affected its operations including decline in natural gas sales and transmission volumes by around 21 million standard cubic meters per day (MSCMD) and 30 MSCMD, respectively, during March as compared to February, the company added.

MITIGATION MEASURES

The company has taken various mitigation measures including procurement of LNG from the spot market and alternative sourcing to manage the impact.

Bulk diesel sales shifting to cheaper retail outlets, straining supplies

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Fuel retail outlets in certain regions are experiencing supply shortages following a significant shift by industrial and commercial consumers, who have abandoned bulk diesel procurement in favour of cheaper retail outlets (retail outlets) operated by public sector oil marketing companies.

“Bulk supplies of diesel are shifting to retail. Demand is shifting to government companies, and we have sufficient supplies,” said Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Oil Ministry.

She said sales at ROs in some regions had jumped 20-30 per cent due to industrial buyers queuing, as the price difference compared to retail consumers is around ₹40-42 per litre. Besides, consumption by the farm sector has also increased.

“Petrol pumps generally have stocks of 2-2.5 days, and if they witness 20-30 per cent demand growth, they may temporarily face some (supply) issues. There are last-mile logistics connectivity issues,” she explained.



BUYER RUSH. Sales at retail outlets in some regions have jumped 20-30 per cent as industrial buyers queue up

Sharma emphasised that India has sufficient supplies of petrol, diesel, LPG and natural gas despite global geopolitical tensions impacting imports, and said the government has taken steps to reduce the burden on citizens.

LPG PRODUCTION UP

India’s production of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) rose marginally from around 45,000-46,000 tonnes per day (TPD) last month to roughly 46,000-47,000 TPD currently, which could be due to the resumption of Nayara Energy’s Vadinar refinery last week after maintenance.

Sharma said, “We have a sufficient supply of crude oil, natural gas, petrol, and diesel. Our refineries are operating at optimum capacity to meet the country’s demand.

“Furthermore, LPG production has been ramped up at the refineries, with around 46,000-47,000 TPD of LPG being produced in the country,” she said.

The LPG supply remains “stable”. In the last three days, 1.34 crore domestic LPG cylinders were delivered against 1.32 crore bookings, with 96 per cent deliveries completed using DAC (delivery authentication code), she added.

Commercial LPG supply

since May 1 stood at around 13,32,000 tonnes, while 23,588 tonnes were sold in the last three days.

Auto LPG sales stood at 963 tonnes, and around 18.87 lakh 5-kg cylinders were sold, he said.

Production by the world’s second largest LPG consumer had plateaued at around 46,000-47,000 TPD in April 2026, compared to roughly 50,000 TPD in the last week of March.

NAYARA MAINTENANCE

This decline was largely due to Nayara Energy’s Vadinar refinery going into maintenance and the OMCs re-prioritising some streams of C3 and C4 molecules for petrochemicals production.

With Nayara Energy’s refinery coming online after a month-long maintenance, it is expected that India’s LPG production will rise to around 48,000-48,500 TPD.

In the natural gas segment since March, Sharma pointed out that 7.64 lakh PNG connections have been gasified, infrastructure has been created for 2.81 lakh connections, and 7.99 lakh new customers have been registered.

Eicher forays into financial services with Volvo Group

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Eicher Motors Ltd on Thursday said its board has approved an investment of up to ₹750 crore to subscribe to 50 per cent equity stake in Volvo Financial Services (VFS) India, to form a new equal joint venture.

Eicher Motors Ltd (EML) and Volvo Group have an existing joint venture, Volvo Eicher Commercial Vehicles Ltd (VECV).

The proposed new JV will be the captive financing arm for VECV, EML and Volvo Group products in India, the company said in a statement. “Expanding our highly successful 18-year partnership with Volvo Group, Eicher is now entering the vehicle financing business in India through a new joint-venture. This JV combines Volvo’s global financial services expertise and Eicher’s local knowledge and network,” EML Chairman Siddhartha Lal said.

The JV will serve Eicher, Volvo and Royal Enfield customers in India and presents an opportunity for EML to

operate in an important segment of the value chain, using financing as a lever for a superior customer experience, he added.

Globally, the Volvo Group offers tailored financial solutions to Volvo’s customers and dealers around the world through Volvo Financial Services (VFS), its captive finance provider.

The statement said that the new JV will combine VFS’ strength and understanding in the financial services with Eicher’s expansive product portfolio, network and deep market understanding to capture new business in a more aligned and efficient manner.

The proposed JV will also deepen integration to accelerate decision-making and help customers in easily accessing financing solutions.

Upon the closing of the transaction, which is contingent upon regulatory approvals, fresh equity shares of the proposed joint venture entity will be issued to EML, it said, adding that the exact investment will be determined at the time of closing, as per the transaction documents.

Stellantis, JLR sign MoU to develop products for US

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Global automotive major Stellantis and Tata Motors-owned Jaguar Land Rover on Wednesday announced that they will explore opportunities to collaborate on product development in the US.

The two firms have signed a memorandum of understanding for the purpose, Stellantis and Jaguar Land Rover (JLR) said in a joint statement.

Under the terms of the non-binding MoU, Stellantis and JLR will explore collaboration opportunities to create synergies across product and technology development, leveraging the companies’ complementary strengths to create value for both organisations, the statement said.

“By working with partners to explore synergies in areas such as product and technology development, we can create meaningful benefits for both sides while remaining focused on delivering the products and experiences

our customers love,” Stellantis CEO Antonio Filosa said.

JLR CEO PB Balaji said, “As we continue to evolve JLR for the future, collaboration will play an important role in unlocking new opportunities.”

He further said, “Working with Stellantis allows us to explore complementary capabilities in product and technology development that support our long-term growth plans for the US market.”

Implementation of any potential transactions as a result of the MoU discussions would be subject to customary closing conditions, including execution of binding definitive agreements, the statement said.

Stellantis, which was formed by the merger between Italian-American conglomerate Fiat Chrysler Automobiles and French PSA Group, has a range of brands, including Abarth, Alfa Romeo, Chrysler, Citroen, Dodge, DS Automobiles, FIAT, Jeep, Maserati, Opel, Peugeot and Vauxhall, among others.

ITC Limited

Extract of Audited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results for the Quarter and Twelve Months ended 31st March, 2026

(₹ in Crores)

Sl. No.	Particulars	Standalone			Consolidated		
		3 Months ended 31.03.2026	Twelve Months ended 31.03.2026	Corresponding 3 Months ended 31.03.2025	3 Months ended 31.03.2026	Twelve Months ended 31.03.2026	Corresponding 3 Months ended 31.03.2025
1	Total Income from continuing operations	22347.42	84927.29	19289.94	24406.63	92339.13	21016.62
2	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period from continuing operations (before tax and Exceptional items)	6691.86	26951.47	6417.07	7197.82	28325.09	6836.12
3	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period from continuing operations before tax (after Exceptional items)	6693.92	26767.60	6417.07	7172.62	28033.39	6836.12
4	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period from continuing operations after tax	5113.36	20286.42	4874.93	5469.74	21018.15	5155.27
5	Net Profit / (Loss) for the period from discontinued operations (before tax and Exceptional items)	-	-	-	-	-	-
6	Exceptional items of discontinued operations	-	-	15179.43	-	-	15145.18
7	Net Profit / (Loss) from discontinued operations for the period after tax	-	-	14686.86	-	-	14652.61
8	Profit for the period [4+7]	5113.36	20286.42	19561.79	5469.74	21018.15	19807.88
9	Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	4229.44	19476.46	18953.49	4678.49	20374.86	19406.29
10	Equity Share Capital	1252.95	1252.95	1251.41	1252.95	1252.95	1251.41
11	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	-	68675.66	-	-	71254.35	-
12	Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 1/- each) (not annualised):						
	1. Basic (for continuing operations) (₹):	4.08	16.20	3.89	4.30	16.52	4.05
	2. Diluted (for continuing operations) (₹):	4.08	16.19	3.89	4.30	16.51	4.05
	3. Basic (for discontinued operations) (₹):	-	-	11.75	-	-	11.72
	4. Diluted (for discontinued operations) (₹):	-	-	11.73	-	-	11.70
	5. Basic (for continuing and discontinued operations) (₹):	4.08	16.20	15.64	4.30	16.52	15.77
	6. Diluted (for continuing and discontinued operations) (₹):	4.08	16.19	15.62	4.30	16.51	15.75

Note:

a) The above is an extract of the detailed format of the Statements of Audited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The audited Financial Results and Segment Results were reviewed and recommended by the Audit Committee, and approved by the Board of Directors of the Company at its meeting held on 21st May, 2026. It is confirmed that the Statutory Auditors of the Company, M/s S R B C & CO LLP, Chartered Accountants, have issued Audit Reports with unmodified opinion on the said Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results. The complete Statements of Audited Standalone and Consolidated Financial Results are available on the Company’s website at <https://itcportal.com/investors/quarterly-results.html> and on the websites of the National Stock Exchange of India Limited (www.nseindia.com) and BSE Limited (www.bseindia.com). The same can also be accessed by scanning the QR Code provided below.

b) Exceptional Items of Continuing Operations for the year ended 31st March, 2026 of ₹ 183.87 Crores in Standalone Financial Results and ₹ 291.70 Crores in Consolidated Financial Results represents:

i) estimated one-time impact on recognition of past service cost of ₹ 271.95 Crores in Standalone Financial Results and ₹ 379.78 Crores in Consolidated Financial Results with respect to increase in liability of gratuity and compensated absences, primarily arising due to change in definition of wages pursuant to notifications issued by the Ministry of Labour & Employment dated 21st November, 2025 bringing into force the provisions of the Code on Wages, 2019, the Industrial Relations Code, 2020, the Code on Social Security, 2020 and the Occupational Safety, Health and Working Conditions Code, 2020 (collectively referred to as the “New Labour Codes”). The Group continues to monitor the finalisation of rules by the Central and State Governments and clarifications from the Government on other aspects of the New Labour Codes and will account for such developments as needed.

ii) receipt of ₹ 88.08 Crores on final settlement of the insurance claim towards leaf tobacco stocks, which were destroyed due to fire at a third party owned warehouse in an earlier year.

c) The Board of Directors of the Company have recommended to the Members for their approval, Final Dividend of ₹ 8.00 per Ordinary Share of ₹ 1/- each for the financial year ended 31st March, 2026 (previous year: Final Dividend of ₹ 7.85 per Ordinary Share). Together with the Interim Dividend of ₹ 6.50 per Ordinary Share (previous year: ₹ 6.50 per Ordinary Share) paid on 27th February, 2026, the total Dividend for the financial year ended 31st March, 2026 amounts to ₹ 14.50 per Ordinary Share (previous year: ₹ 14.35 per Ordinary Share). Total cash outflow on account of Dividend (including Interim Dividend of ₹ 8144.00 Crores paid in February, 2026) will be ₹ 18167.57 Crores (previous year: ₹ 17956.69 Crores).

The Record Date fixed for the purpose of determining entitlement of the Members for the Final Dividend is Wednesday, 27th May, 2026 and such Dividend, if declared, will be paid between Friday, 24th July, 2026 and Wednesday, 29th July, 2026 to those Members entitled thereto.

For and on behalf of the Board

Registered Office:
Virginia House, 37 J.L. Nehru Road, Kolkata 700 071, India
Dated: 21st May, 2026
Place: Kolkata, India

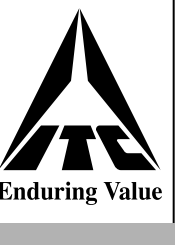
Sd/-
Director & Chief Financial Officer
(DIN: 01804345)

Sd/-
Chairman & Managing Director
(DIN: 00280529)



The Financial Results along with the Audit Reports have been posted on the Company’s website at www.itcportal.com and can be accessed by scanning the QR Code.

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Reforming schools

They must gear up for gig economy, AI churn

India’s school education story, as laid out in a new report by NITI Aayog, begins on an encouraging note. Over the past decade, India has achieved what once seemed elusive: near-universal access to primary schooling, better enrolment among girls and disadvantaged groups, improved basic infrastructure in schools, and signs of recovery in foundational literacy. With 14.7 lakh schools serving nearly 25 crore students, the architecture of access is now largely in place.



Yet, beneath this progress lies a deeper, more troubling truth — India may have succeeded in getting children into schools, but it is struggling to ensure that they stay, learn and emerge ready for a changing economy. While enrolment is robust at the elementary level, participation collapses as children move into secondary and higher secondary education, with gross enrolment at the higher secondary stage just 58.4 per cent. A key reason lies outside the classroom. For millions of low-income families, adolescence marks the point at which education begins to compete directly with survival. Secondary schooling brings transport costs, books, uniforms, exam fees and often private tuition. At the same time, household economic pressures intensify. Many teenagers are pulled into the labour market early.

This challenge is becoming more acute in a new economy increasingly shaped by low-barrier gig work. Delivery platforms, logistics apps and on-demand services offer quick earning opportunities that require little formal qualification. The gig economy, in fact, risks quietly normalising early exit from education for vulnerable families. The tragedy is that this happens even as learning levels remain weak. Too many children are progressing through grades without mastering the basics. The report points to a system still dominated by rote pedagogy and assessment structures that fail to measure real understanding.

India therefore faces a paradox: access has expanded, but learning quality and retention remain fragile; aspiration for private schooling has risen, but quality assurance remains uneven; policy frameworks are modern, but classroom realities lag behind. The answer cannot simply be to keep children in school longer. Schooling itself must become more relevant to the future economy. As artificial intelligence reshapes work, India must rethink education as preparation not for clerical or repetitive jobs, many of which automation will eliminate, but for higher-value roles requiring problem-solving, creativity, digital fluency, design thinking, communication and STEM skills. Secondary schooling must integrate AI literacy, critical thinking and market-linked skills without abandoning foundational learning. India must create an economy that rewards higher skills with better wages. If the future offers only low-paid gig work, families will continue to choose immediate income over long-term education. The challenge lies in building a system that makes staying in school more worthwhile than leaving it early.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



SAUMITRA BHADURI

The Indian rupee continues to slide. Over the last 12 months, it has emerged as one of the weakest-performing currencies not only among Asian peers but also within the BRICS countries.

This is not merely a strong-dollar story. The rupee has depreciated sharply against these currencies: by around 16-18 per cent against the yuan, ringgit, and rand, over 20 per cent against the real and rouble, and nearly 11-12 per cent even against the Pakistani rupee over the past year.

But there is no reason for panic. A currency’s exchange rate reflects only its relative price in foreign exchange markets. It is not a direct measure of an economy’s intrinsic strength, nor does it capture its long-term productive potential. History offers many examples of fast-growing economies experiencing depreciating currencies during periods of adjustment, capital reallocation, or external shocks. Exchange rates ultimately reflect the balance between demand and supply for foreign currency, not a moral verdict on economic management.

THREE FACTORS

The persistent depreciation of the rupee can be attributed to three broad factors. The first is the oil shock stemming from geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, particularly concerns over the Strait of Hormuz. Given India’s huge oil imports, when oil prices rise sharply, the demand for dollars automatically increases because the oil trade is overwhelmingly dollar-denominated. Regardless of supplier diversification, the import bill still translates into sustained pressure on dollar demand.

Second, periods of uncertainty create defensive behaviour in currency markets. Importers, corporates, and financial institutions are beginning to aggressively hedge future liabilities. This amplifies dollar demand beyond immediate trade needs. In such moments, the exchange rate often overshoots fundamentals because market participants are buying protection against future volatility rather than responding solely to current economic conditions.

The third factor, and perhaps the most important from a structural perspective, is the persistent withdrawal of foreign portfolio investment. The concern is not merely over the scale of the exit but its composition. FIIs are no longer trimming exposure only in speculative or mid-cap segments. Data show that they have also reduced holdings in blue-chip Indian firms, suggesting growing caution even toward India’s safest and most liquid assets.

GOVT, RBI RESPONSE

While the distortions arising from geopolitical tensions are largely beyond the control of any single country, they can only be weathered in the short run through prudent market intervention and measures to moderate excessive demand for the dollar. Both the Centre and the RBI are broadly fulfilling their responsibilities in this regard.

On the government side, efforts continue to diversify supply chains, secure alternative sources of crude imports, and rationalise non-essential imports such as gold. So far, these measures appear to have worked reasonably well. Despite severe external stress over recent months, the current account balance has not deteriorated uncontrollably. RBI data show that India’s current account deficit stood at around \$13.2 billion, or 1.3 per cent of GDP, in the latest quarter, significantly lower than the levels during past crises.

This is important because India historically becomes vulnerable when a

weakening currency is accompanied by an unsustainable current account deficit. So far, that threshold has not yet been breached. Strong services exports, robust remittance inflows, and calibrated import management have helped cushion the pressure arising from rising oil imports and capital outflows. In that sense, India still retains enough macroeconomic buffers to weather the present turbulence.

However, the weakest link among the three pressures remains the persistent withdrawal of FPIs. This raises a serious long-term concern because it may reflect a structural shift in how global investors perceive India as an investment destination.

There are a few reasons for this current attrition. First, major central banks, especially the US Federal Reserve, continue to maintain relatively high interest rates, making advanced economy assets attractive.

Second, many foreign investors increasingly view Indian equity markets as overvalued relative to earnings fundamentals, particularly in an environment where the rupee itself is weakening. As a result, many are simply booking profits despite the optimistic narrative surrounding India’s future growth prospects.

AI STORY

Further, global capital today is moving toward the next technological frontier: artificial intelligence. The current AI wave is not merely a technology cycle; it is becoming the organising principle of future productivity growth. Countries

Attempting to artificially defend the rupee would exhaust reserves. RBI’s strategy of smoothing volatility rather than defending a fixed level is the correct approach

attracting capital are those positioned at the frontier of AI research, semiconductor ecosystems, frontier computing, and intellectual property creation. India, unfortunately, remains largely absent from that conversation, and hence, this outflow is unlikely to reverse any time soon unless we witness something close to a miracle.

The immediate priority, therefore, is to manage the short-term crisis pragmatically by allowing the rupee to absorb part of the external shock while continuously monitoring market stability to prevent excessive volatility and speculative attacks. Attempting to artificially defend the currency would only exhaust reserves and worsen vulnerabilities. The RBI’s present strategy of smoothing volatility rather than defending a fixed level remains the correct approach.

However, the long-term challenge is far deeper. Currency stability cannot ultimately be engineered through intervention alone. The only sustainable way India can cope with such external vulnerability is by creating a steady flow of patient capital, and that can only emerge through sustained productivity gains in manufacturing and technology-intensive sectors.

India still faces structural bottlenecks in logistics, supply-chain integration, labour productivity, regulatory complexity, and industrial competitiveness. Without addressing these issues, the country will struggle to attract the kind of long-term capital needed to stabilise the external sector.

At the same time, India must also protect and upgrade its service-led export engine, which will increasingly face disruption from AI-driven automation. The falling rupee is therefore a warning that the global economy is changing rapidly. India must adapt far more aggressively if it wants to remain an attractive destination for global capital in the decade ahead.

The writer is Professor, Madras School of Economics

Benefits of TN working women’s hostel scheme

Tamil Nadu has shown the way for providing safe housing for single working women. Other States must emulate this model

Vidya Mahambare
Arti Srivastava

Governments change. Policies change with them. One Tamil Nadu policy, however, deserves to outlast political transitions — the construction of hostels for women migrants, built and run in partnership with the private sector.

Women migrate more than men; around 87 per cent of female migration is marriage-related, and less than 5 per cent is employment-related, according to the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation’s Migration in India survey.

One of the key reasons for low migration among women for paid work is the lack of infrastructure that can help convert women’s aspirations into employment, specifically a safe to live.

Female enrolment in higher education now matches male enrolment. Yet this achievement sits awkwardly alongside a persistent reality: less than half of even ‘single’ women aged 24-29 are in paid work, based on periodic labour survey data.

For single women, the usual barriers - care work, household responsibilities, family obligations - are not yet in play. What holds many of them back from moving to cities for work is lack of safe, affordable housing.

Urban jobs in sectors such as IT ,



healthcare, finance, and education are concentrated in cities, but unlike manufacturing clusters, where employer-provided dormitories are common, these sectors do not offer on-site or off-site accommodation.

A young woman moving to Chennai, Bengaluru, or Gurgaon from the interior parts for her first job must navigate an unfamiliar housing market independently, often without contacts, in an environment where her family’s approval of the move hinges on whether she can live by herself safely.

If safe urban residence remains unavailable to women migrants, the returns to female education remain unrealised.

Tamil Nadu appears to have recognised this. The State established the Tamil Nadu Working Women’s Hostels Corporation Ltd in 2019, to build and operate hostels under the brand

name Thozhi, meaning ‘friend’ in Tamil. The network now spans 19 locations, operates in a public-private partnership, has over 1,800 beds, and maintains an overall occupancy rate of approximately 87 per cent as of October 2025, with all five Chennai hostels near full capacity, according to administrative data.

The Chennai hostels alone house residents from Tamil Nadu and at least 12 other States and union territories.

SURVEY FINDINGS

A study of the Thozhi hostel model, conducted by the authors of this article (together with Niharika Gowthaman, Rammyaa M, and Swetha Shree R) sheds light on how the model operates and why it has become a success.

The findings show that the hostels operate as labour-market infrastructure bridging the gap between a woman’s decision to work and her ability to stay in the city long enough for that decision to take hold. Residents consistently describe a pathway in which secure government-backed housing enables something far more fundamental than shelter: it provides the stability that allows routine formation, and routine that makes sustained employment possible.

Women who would otherwise have been unable to migrate because their families were not satisfied with private hostels or because they could not afford

private accommodation, describe the hostel as the enabling condition. Several noted that without the assurance of a government stamp, their parents would not have permitted their move. The hostel operates as a socially recognised safe space.

Room rents across Thozhi hostels range from under ₹2,000 per month in smaller towns to around ₹10,000 for single AC rooms in Chennai, broadly aligned with entry-level service sector salaries. Many residents report remitting part of their salary home, saving, and deferring expensive housing commitments until careers stabilise.

Of course, there is always room for operational improvement. Food quality and student occupancy (since any woman over age 18 can apply to stay), which could potentially crowd out working women, are issues that managements can address.

Other States should study and can replicate the model. The institutional design — government backing, which generates family trust, professional management, digitised administration, and affordable tiered pricing — is transferable. Second, ensure appropriate revenue-sharing models with private operators that preserves credibility, safety standards and affordability norms.

The writers teach at Great Lakes Institute of Management, Chennai

● **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Rupee worries

This refers to ‘Test of rupee resilience’ (May 21). Though RBI intervention has made some positive changes in the value of the rupee, the dollar remains strong impacting BoP and the current account. The persisting geopolitical tensions and resulting interruptions in demand and supply are leading to an inflationary spiral. Despite the depreciating value of the rupee, exporters are unable to capitalise on the opportunity on account of the rising input costs for manufacturing goods.

Apart from the sale of dollars by the RBI, import of goods other than for necessities needs to be drastically curtailed outflow of dollars. Raising the interest rate on FCNR deposits and making equities, derivatives and debt securities are crucial to attract investment inflows.
YSK Pillai
Changanacherry (Kerala)

Fair recovery norms

Apropos ‘RBI revises loan recovery norms after feedback’ (May 21). The RBI’s revised draft amendments are a welcome step to protect

borrowers from harassment. The proposed rules on mobile phone disabling tools, conduct of lenders and engagement of recovery agents address several long-standing customer concerns. Fixing timelines for restoration of device functions or compensation will enhance accountability among regulated entities. Restrictions on the timing and manner of recovery calls will help safeguard customer dignity and privacy. However, these stricter directions will be meaningful only if recovery

agencies are closely monitored and violations are acted upon promptly.
PV Prakash
Mumbai

Charging thrust

Apropos “Taking charge” (May 21). The need to expand EV charging infrastructure under the PM E-DRIVE scheme is clear, especially as crude oil prices keep reminding us of our import dependence. Yet the real bottleneck remains the fragmented standards and app ecosystem that frustrates ordinary users. For EVs to become truly practical,

charging stations must be fully vehicle-agnostic, allowing any car or two-wheeler to plug in without hassle. PSUs should focus on dense, reliable networks within a three-kilometre radius in cities while mandating open platforms for booking and payment. Simple, uniform norms at the hardware level, backed by solar integration where possible, would go a long way in building user confidence and accelerating adoption.
K Sakunthala
Coimbatore

QUICKLY.

Alpha AMC eyes ₹1,000 cr for VentureX SME Fund



New Delhi: Alpha AMC, an alternative investment management firm, is targeting a corpus of ₹1,000 crore for its flagship product, VentureX SME Fund, a top company official said. The fund crossed total commitments of ₹223 crore as of April 30, 2026. Rajesh Singla, CEO and Fund Manager, Alpha AMC, told PTI the firm focuses on investing in SMEs at the pre-IPO and IPO stage, identifying businesses with strong fundamentals and high-growth potential before broader institutional participation. “The biggest wealth creation opportunities often emerge in businesses that are still in their growth phase. Larger companies provide stability, but smaller, fundamentally strong companies can scale faster, compound earnings consistently and create disproportionate long-term value for investors,” he said.

SEBI, NISM, IICA sign MoU on governance, markets

New Delhi: The National Institute of Securities Markets (NISM), set up by SEBI and the Indian Institute of Corporate Affairs (IICA) under the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, have signed a memorandum of understanding (MoU) to strengthen corporate governance, ESG frameworks and capital markets in India. Under the agreement, the two institutions will jointly design certification courses, executive education modules and training programmes, including specialised programmes for SEBI officials and other regulatory and financial sector professionals.

SEBI proposes new rules for price discovery in IPOs, re-listed stocks

ON THE CARDS. Revised base price norms, automatic price band widening, stricter auction criteria

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India has proposed a new framework for price discovery in IPOs and re-listed stocks, including changes to base price calculations, automatic widening of dummy price bands and stricter conditions for successful price discovery during the pre-open call auction session. SEBI has proposed using the latest closing price within the previous six months as the base price for re-listed shares if trading resumes within six months of suspension. If no recent traded price is available, then the lower book value certified by two independent chartered accountants or valuation agen-

cies can be used. For stocks returning after more than six months of suspension, exchanges will directly use the lower valuation certified by two independent valuers as the base price.

PRICE MECHANISM

SEBI also proposed continuing the existing dummy price band mechanism for IPOs, SME IPOs and re-listed stocks, but with automatic and immediate flexing of bands by 10 per cent when equilibrium prices near the upper or lower range.

Exchanges will also continue widening bands during the random closure period between 9:35 am and 9:45 am. They can widen price bands when orders exist only on one side of the market, but only after validating orders



THE CONTENTION. SEBI had received representations that the current mechanism was leading to ‘artificially suppressed price discovery’

from at least five PAN-based unique investors.

The regulator has proposed that a call auction session will qualify as successful only if at least five unique buyers and five unique sellers participate in price discovery.

If price discovery fails on

the first day for a re-listed stock or a stock undergoing corporate restructuring, the call auction session will continue on subsequent trading days until a price is discovered.

The existing dummy price band and base price mechanism were creating persistent

buying pressure after listing, leading to repeated upper circuits.

“In one of the instances, it was observed that during the Call Auction Session of the re-listed scrip, 90 per cent of the buy orders were rejected due to being outside the price bands,” SEBI said in the consultation paper.

EXISTING NORMS

At present, re-listed stocks suspended for over a year generally begin trading with a base price linked to face value or book value, which SEBI noted “in most of the cases” starts at ₹10.

SEBI has sought comments on the proposals till June 11, including whether the revised dummy price band mechanism should also apply to SME IPOs.

Six Capital Group-linked FPIs receive show-cause notice in front running case

Our Bureau
Mumbai

SEBI has issued show-cause notices to six foreign portfolio investors linked to US-based Capital Group in connection with its ongoing front-running investigation, according to people familiar with the matter.

The entities that have received the notices are American Funds Insurance Series Growth-Income Fund, American Funds Fundamental Investors, Smallcap World Fund, The Growth Fund of America, AMCAP Fund and Capital Group AM-

CAP Fund (Lux), they said. Capital Group declined to comment due to the ongoing nature of the matter. SEBI did not respond to the queries until press time.

REGULATORY PROBE

The proceedings stem from SEBI’s interim order issued in 2025 against Singapore-based trader Rohit Salgaocar and Ketan Parekh, in which the regulator alleged that confidential information relating to trades by a “big client” was used for front-run trades in the market. SEBI had not identified Capital Group in the interim order.

SEB alleged that Salgaocar,

a Director at Strait Crossing, received information relating to impending trades from two traders linked to Capital Group, and shared it further with a network of traders linked to market operator Ketan Parekh. Salgaocar was in a referral agreement with Indian intermediaries Motilal Oswal Financial Services and Nuvama Wealth Management to refer trades of the client to them.

Salgaocar has appealed against SEBI’s interim order and is being heard before the Securities Appellate Tribunal. In November last year, SAT allowed Salgaocar’s plea seeking cross-examina-

tion of Parekh and directed SEBI to provide a date for the process.

“The matter will be closely watched by institutional investors and intermediaries as it could lead to closer scrutiny of internal controls and information-sharing practices followed during large institutional trades, particularly between intermediaries,” said a securities lawyer, wishing not to be named.

Another person said the case could further shape regulations around communication protocols and access to trade-related information within institutional dealing operations.

See-saw Nifty surrenders initial gains to end flat

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

The markets ended a see-saw session nearly flat on Thursday as a firm opening driven by easing geopolitical fears and softer crude prices gave way to broad-based profit booking that wiped out over 200 points from intra-day highs. The reversal underscored a market still caught between pockets of optimism and stubborn macro headwinds.

“Valuations in large caps are now below long-term averages after the recent correction,” said Sorbh Gupta, Head of Equity, Bajaj Finserv AMC, reflecting the cautious but selective opportunities the market presents.

The Nifty 50 settled at 23,654.70, down just 4.3 points, after touching an intra-day high of 23,859.90 within the first few minutes of trade. The Sensex fell 135.03 points or 0.18 per

cent to close at 75,183.36. The Nifty Smallcap 100 advanced 0.63 per cent, while the Nifty Midcap 100 ended marginally lower by 0.04 per cent. Market breadth stayed positive for the third consecutive session, with 290 stocks in the Nifty 500 ending in the green. India VIX declined 3.35 per cent to close at 17.82, suggesting cooling volatility even as benchmark indices struggled.

SECTORAL WATCH

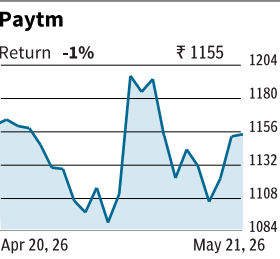
Sectorally, realty, cement, consumer durables and healthcare ended with gains, while IT, FMCG and media faced selling pressure. Nifty IT, despite surging 3.2 per cent, did not prevent the broader index from slipping as profit booking hit heavyweights. Bajaj Finance, Hindustan Unilever and Tech Mahindra were among the notable laggards, while Grasim, IndiGo and Apollo Hospitals topped the gainers list.

Elevation Capital to sell 1.3% stake in Paytm owner; floor price: ₹1,120.65

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Funds associated with Elevation Capital are set to offload a significant stake in One 97 Communications Ltd, the parent company of Paytm, through a bulk share sale on the stock exchanges.

Saif III Mauritius Company Ltd, Saif Partners India IV Ltd, will collectively sell up to 8.6 million shares, representing approximately 1.3 per cent of Paytm’s total outstanding stock. The two funds combined held a 13.43 per cent stake in the fintech as of March-end, according to exchange data.



The offer floor price has been fixed at ₹1,120.65 per share, reflecting a 2.99 per cent discount to Paytm’s closing price of ₹1,155.30 on the BSE. The sale is expected to raise around ₹963.6 crore (approximately \$100 million).

Citigroup Global Markets

India Private Ltd has been appointed as the placement agent for the transaction, which is scheduled to be executed on May 22, 2026.

The transaction will be entirely secondary, with no new issuance of shares. The sellers will be subject to a 30-day lock-up period on their residual holdings.

Buyers will incur brokerage charges of 25 basis points, in addition to standard market fees. Settlement is expected on May 25, 2026, one trading day after execution.

Paytm turned in a net profit of ₹552 crore for the full year FY26 compared to ₹663 crore loss year ago.

Lenskart zooms even as Q4 profit falls, but analysts give thumbs up

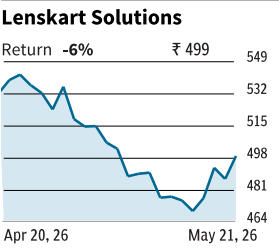
Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Shares of Lenskart surged over 6 per cent to ₹517 before settling with modest gains of 2.9 per cent at ₹498.50 on Thursday even as the eyewear major reported a decline in fourth-quarter profit, with investors cheering robust revenue growth, aggressive store expansion and strong management commentary on future growth.

The eyewear maker reported a 7.5 per cent y-o-y decline in consolidated profit after tax to ₹203.6 crore for the quarter ended March 31, 2026, compared to ₹220.1 crore in the year-ago period, mainly due to higher expenses on components and inventories.

REVENUE SURGE

However, revenue from operations jumped 45.62 per cent



y-o-y to around ₹2,516 crore in Q4FY26 from ₹1,728 crore a year earlier, reflecting strong demand, premiumisation and rapid store additions. Lenskart accelerated store expansion during FY26, adding 542 net new stores in India, nearly double compared to FY25, with a sharp focus on tier-2 and smaller markets.

Lenskart further announced plans to invest around ₹53 crore to increase its stake in overseas subsidiaries Owndays and Lenskart Singapore. The company will acquire an additional 1 per

cent stake in Japanese arm Owndays for about ₹50 crore, taking its indirect ownership to around 97.67 per cent.

OVERWEIGHT

Global brokerage Jefferies maintained a ‘Buy’ rating on the stock and raised its target price to ₹600, saying Lenskart delivered another standout quarter with strong growth and margin improvement.

The brokerage said AI integration across the value chain and control over manufacturing continue to strengthen the company’s competitive positioning.

Morgan Stanley maintained an ‘Overweight’ rating with a target price of ₹576, saying Q4 results beat estimates and reflected another strong quarter. The brokerage said Lenskart remains focused on sustaining growth, while reiterating its long-term EBITDA margin target of around 25 per cent.

BROKER’S CALL.

Motilal Oswal Research

INDRAPRASTHA GAS (BUY)

Target: ₹220
CMP: ₹154.55
Indraprastha Gas’ (IGL) Q4FY26 EBITDA/scm came in 44 per cent above our estimate at ₹4.8. Gas costs and opex increased about ₹1/0.8 per scm quarter on quarter in Q4. Total volumes were slightly below our estimate at 9.69 mmscmd, rising 6 per cent year on year. Resulting EBITDA beat our estimate by 51 per cent at ₹420 crore (~15 per cent year on year). IGL’s PAT beat our estimate by 44 per cent at ₹280 crore (~21 per cent). CNG volumes grew 5.5 per cent year on year. The management has guided for a robust 10.6 mmscmd exit volume for FY27, driven by 10-13 per cent growth in CNG volumes, and EBITDA margins at ₹7-8/scm. IGL has connected a total of 3.44m D-PNG customers, of which 2.45 million are currently billed. Under PNG Drive 2.0, the company is targeting 0.35 million new billed domestic connections in FY27, supported by a strong pipeline of about 0.5 million already-connected but non-consuming customers. The management indicated that gas procurement costs have increased about 25 per cent from pre-geopolitical crisis levels (Q3FY26 gas cost: ₹35.8/scm). However, it has taken a ₹3/kg price hike, which is likely to provide margin support. Volumes are expected to remain weak in Q1FY27. We value IGL at 15x December 2027E SA P/E and add ₹43/share as the value of JVs to arrive at our TP of ₹220. At 2 per cent FY27E dividend yield and 18 per cent EPS CAGR over FY26-28, we believe the valuation is attractive. Reiterate Buy.

IDBI Capital Equity Research

ASTRAL (BUY)

Target: ₹1,714
CMP: ₹1,480.50
Astral’s Q4FY26 result was broadly in-line with our estimates on net sales and EBITDA, while PAT was a disappointment. After a relatively-muted 9MFY26 performance, it reported a good show in Q4FY26 on key parameters. Net sales increased 24.2 per cent year on year to ₹2,090 crore, while EBITDA came in at ₹380 crore, up 26.8 per cent. It reported net profit of ₹210 crore, up 19.6 per cent.

Astral has guided for a plumbing volume growth of 10-15 per cent for FY27. The company has guided for healthy growth in its core businesses in the near term. Further, the backward integration plant for CPVC resin is under active construction with machinery installation set for October. The management expects this backward integration to expand piping margins by about 200 basis points. The management indicated that the three-year polymer deflation cycle has bottomed out, giving way to an inflationary trend. Prices are expected to rise further due to the reinstatement of a 7.5-8 per cent import duty on polymers, effective July 1. We have marginally revised our earnings estimates upward, aligning it with the management guidance. Post recent correction in the stock price, value looks lucrative from current level. We upgrade the stock to Buy with a revised TP of ₹1,714, assigning 55x PER on FY28E.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

TODAY’S PICK.

Dr Agarwal’s Health Care (₹480.70): BUY

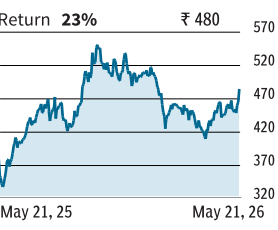
Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for Dr. Agarwal’s Health Care. The 4 per cent rise on Wednesday has take the share price well above the key resistance level of ₹470.

This also confirms an inverted head and shoulder pattern on the chart. This is bullish pattern. The neckline support is at ₹470. Resistance is around ₹500. We see high chances for the stock to break this resistance. Such a break can take Dr Agarwal’s Health Care share price higher to ₹535 in the coming weeks.

Traders can buy Dr Agarwal’s Health Care shares now at ₹481. Accumulate on dips at ₹473.

Dr Agarwal’s Health Care



Keep the stop-loss at ₹454. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹488 when the price goes up to ₹496. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹495 and ₹505 when the price touches ₹503 and ₹512 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹525.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23635 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
23530	23380	23670	23850	Take fresh shorts below 23530. Keep the stop-loss at 23570	
₹759 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
755	748	763	770	Take fresh longs only above 763 with a stop-loss at 761	
₹1178 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1160	1145	1190	1205	Go short now and at 1185. Keep the stop-loss at 1195	
₹308 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
306	301	311	315	Go short only below 306. Stop-loss can be kept at 307	
₹296 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
292	290	298	301	Wait for dips. Go long at 293. Keep the stop-loss at 291	
₹1350 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1340	1320	1375	1390	Go short only below 1340. Stop-loss can be kept at 1335	
₹950 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
945	935	960	967	Mixed and unclear. Avoid trading the stock for now	
₹2325 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2315	2290	2335	2350	Go short on a break below 2315. Keep the stop-loss at 2325	

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▼ 4.30 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Grasim Ind	3154.50	15.22	22.67	1.11	
ICI Bank	1242.80	8.57	15.36	0.19	
IntiGlobeBv	4403.00	6.83	53.02	0.92	
Bhavani Elec	420.40	5.54	50.69	1.39	
Apollo Hosp	8308.50	5.16	64.03	0.79	
Bajaj Auto	10667.00	4.94	28.19	1.09	
L&T	3928.50	4.56	28.51	4.25	
Hindalco	1099.30	4.36	15.36	1.47	
Trent Ltd.	4170.40	3.41	86.13	0.85	
Adani Ports	1793.30	3.33	32.32	1.22	
Tata Steel	208.58	2.83	23.92	1.59	
Sun Pharma	1891.30	2.54	41.43	1.85	
Max Healthcare	1091.10	2.50	74.82	0.75	
Axis Bank	1253.30	2.19	14.67	3.31	
HDFC Life	614.35	2.17	69.32	0.61	
UltraTech Cement	11474.00	1.68	41.29	1.25	
Wipro	199.74	1.63	15.79	0.53	
Eicher Motors	6892.00	1.28	35.29	0.87	
ITC	308.05	1.05	18.64	2.74	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	235.78	0.79	95.97	0.71	
Coal India	460.20	0.74	9.13	0.96	
Cipla	1401.90	0.29	29.32	0.73	
Maruti Suzuki	1372.80	0.56	27.86	1.57	
Tata Motors PV	361.35	0.05	44.57	2.72	
Asian Paints	2598.80	0.02	63.75	1.08	
State Bank	950.90	0.00	10.13	3.64	
TCS	2327.20	-0.04	17.03	21.19	
PowerGrid Corp	299.55	-0.35	17.49	1.25	
HCL Tech	1168.20	-0.37	19.94	1.14	
JSW Steel	1281.30	-0.39	12.28	1.11	
SBI Life	1859.90	-0.42	75.52	0.77	
Adani Enter	2697.60	-0.45	35.02	0.71	
Dr Reddys Lab	1318.50	-0.45	26.47	0.74	
HDFC Bank	759.15	-1.17	14.75	10.71	
TataConsumerProduct	1194.90	-1.96	76.44	0.72	
Eternal Ltd.	2.00	-0.03	68.22	1.61	
ONGC	295.85	-2.08	8.28	1.06	
Titan	4083.10	-2.10	71.44	1.55	
NestleIndia	1406.50	-2.13	77.51	0.93	
Bajaj Finserv	1752.20	-2.49	14.26	0.93	
Tech Mahindra	1420.00	-2.63	28.95	0.83	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	514.75	-2.66	21.47	1.18	
Kotak Bank	380.85	-3.77	19.64	2.58	
NTPC	388.80	-3.77	15.18	1.70	
M&M	3099.00	-4.52	20.69	2.55	
Hind Unilever	2179.00	-5.86	48.38	1.78	
Bajaj Finance	907.65	-9.01	29.21	2.24	
Infays	1181.20	-9.56	16.25	8.82	
Bharti Airtel	1885.30	-13.12	33.96	5.33	
Reliance Ind	1249.60	-14.87	19.07	8.40	
Pts: Impact on index movement					

Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 144.05 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Samvardmotheresoninternat	137.00	60.34	39.73	2.46	
Siemens Energy India	3574.50	28.69	97.19	1.28	
Indian Oilcorp	140.53	26.26	4.54	2.13	
Hdfc Amc	2727.30	24.50	40.89	2.26	
Hindustaneronautics	4370.40	23.51	32.06	3.37	
Hyundai Motor India .	1845.20	23.27	27.60	1.07	
Varun Beverages .	519.85	22.60	54.78	2.89	
Cg Power & Ind Sol	864.90	22.56	113.82	2.41	
Bpcl	296.40	15.16	4.98	2.44	
Pollindia	1472.80	15.06	60.67	1.86	
Solar Industries	18392.00	12.52	95.83	1.82	
Tvs Motor Cp.	3380.70	12.46	50.41	3.22	
Torani Pharma	447.10	11.81	65.57	1.97	
Ambuja Cement	436.45	10.67	19.63	1.08	
Dif	587.95	8.42	32.97	1.53	
Three Cement	24605.00	6.98	50.77	1.34	
Power Finance	431.00	6.78	4.23	2.55	
Union Bank	160.12	6.11	62.96	1.26	
Trident Pharma	376.60	6.04	83.57	1.34	
Indian Railway Finance Corp	88.17	5.91	18.30	0.80	
Mazagon Dock	2454.80	3.65	35.94	0.76	
Macrotech Developers .	883.75	2.98	25.73	1.01	
Canara Bank	127.97	2.95	6.49	1.75	
Rural Elec	333.70	2.47	5.39	1.69	
Gail India	186.10	1.98	11.91	1.71	
Tata Motors Cv	118.79	1.18	4.62	2.22	
Abb India	6598.00	-1.04	88.48	1.41	
Bank Of Baroda	263.10	-2.36	6.78	1.98	
Avenuesuper	4137.20	-2.91	90.65	2.47	
Punjab Natl Bank	101.92	-2.92	6.34	1.43	
Hindus Zinc	628.05	-2.94	19.19	1.11	
Polysulfidesciences	110.45	-3.11	20.35	1.05	
Tata Capital	297.80	-3.41	25.85	0.52	
Ltintimedr	4129.70	-3.48	24.57	1.56	
Cummins India	539.00	-3.62	66.65	2.96	
Adani Energy Solutions	1342.20	-3.82	67.39	1.89	
Britannia Ind	5333.00	-3.82	50.63	2.95	
Powerselectrometry	47.70	-4.73	21.47	0.85	
Indian Hotels Co.	657.40	-5.45	41.64	2.34	
Godrej Consumer	1107.30	-6.36	55.92	1.66	
Bajaj Holdings	10402.00	-8.07	11.83	1.83	
United Spirits .	127.62	-10.01	49.58	1.53	
Adani Power .	219.33	-10.63	32.61	3.68	
Divis Labs	329.70	-11.08	12.39	1.89	
Divis Lab	6858.00	-12.56	73.44	3.54	
Tata Power	410.50	-14.58	25.63	2.79	
Cholamandalam&fin	1504.00	-18.01	24.48	2.62	
VEDANTA	329.75	-19.19	8.13	2.28	
Jindal Steel	1196.80	-27.50	36.33	1.80	
Bosch	35210.00	-39.66	37.67	1.24	
Pts: Impact on index movement					

QUICKLY.

FSIB picks up Sivakumar for position of IIFCL DMD

New Delhi: FSIB, the headhunter for directors of state-owned banks and financial institutions, on Thursday recommended TD Sivakumar for the position of Deputy Managing Director (DMD) of India Infrastructure Finance Company Ltd (IIFCL). Sivakumar, who is currently serving as the Chief General Manager at India Exim Bank, would be the second DMD in the state-run financial institution. Palash Srivastava has been serving as Deputy Managing Director of IIFCL since July 2025. PTI

Scapia raises \$63 million led by General Catalyst

Bengaluru: Travel fintech company Scapia has raised \$63 million in a round led by General Catalyst, with continued participation from existing investors Peak XV Partners and Z47. The company will deploy the funds to expand its product portfolio across its financial services and travel segments. OUR BUREAU

At 271 GW, peak power demand spikes for fourth straight day

ENERGY SURGE. Consumption at a record high as rising temperatures drive heavier use of cooling appliances

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Peak power demand met during the day surpassed the Power Ministry's estimate for FY27, hitting 270.82 GW. This is also the fourth consecutive day with power demand breaking all past records.

“Today was the 4th consecutive day when the peak power demand (solar hours) reached a new all-time high. At 1545 hours (21.5.2026), the peak power demand (solar hours) of 270.82 GW was successfully met,” the Power Ministry on said Thursday on X.

The surge in demand appears to be linked to the greater usage of cooling appliances in view of the prevailing weather conditions across the country, it added.

“Today’s peak demand was met with the following



HOT SALES. The surge in demand appears to be linked to the greater usage of cooling appliances in view of the prevailing weather conditions across the country PTI

mix: Thermal 62.8 per cent, solar 22 per cent, wind 5 per cent, hydro 5.8 per cent and rest from other sources. The availability of coal at the thermal power plants (TPPs) is adequate and the supplies are being effectively monitored,” it said.

COAL RESERVES
Coal reserves at TPP were a little over 51.98 million tonnes (mt) on May 18 against a daily consumption

of roughly 3.10 mt. This is for a cumulative coal-based capacity of around 223 GW. Of this, domestic coal-based (DCB) plants with 203 GW installed capacity have stocks of 49.3 mt with a daily requirement of 2.9 mt. Imported coal-based plants (18.78 GW capacity) have stocks of 2.7 mt with a daily requirement of 1.96 lakh tonnes.

Peak power demand during solar hours hit a record

260 GW on Tuesday, surpassing the 257 GW record made on Monday. However, the peak demand surpassed 265 GW on Wednesday, and eventually surpassed 270 GW on Thursday.

The Power Ministry estimated peak demand to be in the range of 270 GW in the current fiscal year.

Disha Aggarwal, Senior Programme Lead at Council On Energy, Environment and Water, said, “India crossed 270 GW of peak demand at 15:47 hrs today. Record heat and surging electricity demand continue to test the power system. A 256 GW peak demand in the week of April 20 already highlighted how thin the margins are becoming: surplus solar during the day, nearly 190 GW of installed coal capacity running at full capacity during nights with up to 5.4 GW of night-time shortage, and exchange

prices swinging five-fold between solar and non-solar hours.

FOUR FRONTS

With projections pointing to 270 GW peak in the coming weeks and hotter nights becoming the norm, India must urgently act on four fronts, she emphasised. “First, fast-track the commissioning of 9.7 GW of battery and pumped hydro storage, planned for FY27, to utilise cheaper and surplus solar power during nights. Second, ensure adequate coal stocks are maintained, especially at plants distant from mines. Third, expand the application of time-of-day tariffs so that smart-metered consumers can optimise evening consumption. Fourth, equip discoms with AI-driven, weather-linked tools to anticipate demand hotspots to prevent transformer failures.”

Credit Saison raises \$500 million via ECB

Our Bureau
Mumbai



Credit Saison India has raised \$500 million through a multi-currency external commercial borrowing (ECB) syndication, marking the largest overseas borrowing exercise in the company's history and taking its cumulative ECB fundraising past \$1.1 billion in just over a year.

The syndication saw participation from a mix of multi-lateral, domestic and international lenders, including the inaugural involvement of Asian Development Bank, alongside returning lenders such as State Bank of India, Mizuho Bank, Axis Bank, CTBC Bank and DBS Bank.

EXPANSION PLAN

The funds will be deployed to expand the company's MSME and secured lending businesses, with a focus on improving financial inclusion and extending credit access to underserved borrowers, including women

entrepreneurs and small businesses.

Credit Saison said ADB's participation would support its efforts to strengthen social and environmental governance standards while scaling its lending operations. A majority of the borrowing tranche was routed through GIFT City, an indicator of the growing role of India's international financial services hub in facilitating cross-border funding.

Presha Paragash, Whole-time Director and CEO of Credit Saison India, said the participation of ADB and returning lenders reflected confidence in the company's governance standards and inclusive lending practices.

Wellness pays: Refunds for over 2 lakh Aditya Birla Health customers in FY26

Avinash Naik
Ahmedabad

More than 9,200 customers of Aditya Birla Health Insurance Company Ltd got 100 per cent of their annual health insurance premium back in FY26 under the company's wellness-linked insurance programme, as the insurer increasingly uses rewards for healthy behaviour to improve customer retention and manage rising medical costs.

Overall, around 2.03 lakh customers earned between 6 per cent and 100 per cent of their premiums back in FY26, accounting for nearly 11 per cent of eligible customers, up from 8.5 per cent in FY25 and around 6 per cent in FY24, Mayank Bathwal, Chief Executive Officer of Aditya Birla Health Insurance, told *businessline*.

“The idea is simple — if customers stay healthy, hospitalisation chances reduce, claims reduce and the overall insurance portfolio improves,” Bathwal said during a visit to Ahmedabad to launch “Activ Yuva”, a wellness-focused health insurance plan targeted at younger consumers.

‘HEALTH FIRST’ MODEL
The insurer said customers who actively participated in wellness programmes showed over 8 per cent better claim ratios and more than 11 per cent higher policy renewals, encouraging the company to



The idea is simple — if customers stay healthy, hospitalisation chances reduce, claims reduce and the overall insurance portfolio improves

MAYANK BATHWAL,
CEO, Aditya Birla Health Insurance



deepen its focus on preventive healthcare and fitness-linked incentives.

Bathwal said the company launched its “Health First” model in 2016 to engage customers beyond just selling insurance policies. “Mainly people above 35 buy health insurance and because of lifelong renewability, portfolios age over time. We wanted to work with customers to help them lead healthier lives. If customers are healthy, our claims come down and the business becomes better,” he said.

The company's push towards wellness-linked insurance comes even as health insurers grapple with steep medical inflation, which Bathwal estimated at 12–14 per cent annually. “If healthcare costs keep rising at 12–14 per cent, technically premiums also have to rise by similar levels because we are ultimately paying hospitals on behalf of customers,” he said.

According to Bathwal, healthcare inflation — rather than distribution ex-

penses — remains the biggest reason behind rising insurance premiums. “India has to find a way to make healthcare affordable. We cannot run the US model,” he said.

CHANGING BEHAVIOUR
The insurer said consumer behaviour has also shifted sharply after Covid, with customers opting for higher coverage despite rising premiums.

“Today, around 80 per cent of our business comes from policies with sum assured above ₹10 lakh. People do not want to compromise on healthcare quality,” Bathwal said.

Aditya Birla Health Insurance currently covers around 24 million customers and reported overall growth of around 39 per cent, with nearly half the growth coming from customer additions and the rest from higher ticket sizes.

The company is also increasing the use of AI and automation in underwriting and claims processing.

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Extract of Audited Financial Results for the quarter and year ended March 31, 2026					
₹ in lakhs					
Particulars	3 months ended 31.03.2026	Preceding 3 months ended 31.12.2025	Corresponding 3 months ended 31.03.2025	Year ended 31.03.2026	Year ended 31.03.2025
Total revenue from operations	1,25,259.94	1,38,675.71	1,09,807.02	5,24,677.58	4,93,490.95
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before exceptional items and tax expenses	23,780.13	29,125.77	21,867.77	1,06,034.19	97,857.93
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after Exceptional and/or Extraordinary items)	23,780.13	25,625.35	21,867.77	1,02,533.77	97,857.93
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax	17,873.04	18,953.64	16,400.50	76,382.32	72,914.19
Total Comprehensive Income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	18,232.00	19,005.01	16,099.12	76,463.49	72,488.58
Equity Share Capital	1,115.39	1,115.39	1,115.39	1,115.39	1,115.39
Other equity				1,49,144.42	1,39,604.18
Earnings Per Share (Face value of ₹10/- each) (for continuing and discontinued operations) -					
a) Basic (₹)	160.24	169.93	147.04	684.81	653.71
b) Diluted (₹)	160.24	169.93	147.04	684.81	653.71

Note:

- The above is an extract of the detailed format of Quarterly Audited Ind AS Financial Results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the Financial Results are available on the websites of the National Stock Exchange of India Limited (www.nseindia.com), BSE Limited (www.bseindia.com) and on the Company's website (www.pageind.com)
- The detailed financial results and this extract were reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved at the meeting of the Board of Directors of the Company at the meeting held on 21st May 2026.



Place : Bengaluru, India
Dated : 21st May, 2026

For Page Industries Limited
sd/-) V S Ganesh
Managing Director
DIN No.: 07822261

Reliable energy for India's rising aspirations

AUDITED STANDALONE AND CONSOLIDATED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER & FINANCIAL YEAR ENDED 31st MARCH, 2026

Pursuant to Regulation 52(4) SEBI (Listing and Other Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015

The results can be accessed through the following link:
https://bit.ly/GAIL_AFR_2026
or scan:



Follow us on:

By order of the Board
GAIL (India) Limited

Sd/-
R. K. Jain
Director (Finance) & CFO
DIN: 08788595
Date: 21.05.2026
Place: New Delhi

HIGHLIGHTS (FY 2025-26)

Pipeline network scaled to
18,400 + km

Doubling the capacity of Jamnagar-Loni LPG pipeline from
3.25 MMTPA to 6.5 MMTPA

Highest-ever LPG throughput of
4,600 TMT achieved



GAIL (India) Limited
(A Govt. of India Undertaking)

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QUICKLY.

Venugopal Dhoot moves SC on VIL-VOVL insolvency

New Delhi: Videocon founder Venugopal Dhoot has moved the Supreme Court against a National Company Law Appellate Tribunal order upholding separate insolvency proceedings for two group entities — Videocon Industries Ltd and Videocon Oil Ventures Ltd — while setting aside an earlier NCLT order that had directed the clubbing of the cases. Dhoot filed the petition on May 19 against the May 14 order of the appellate tribunal.

Lava to invest ₹1,100 crore for electronic components

New Delhi: Home-grown mobile phone maker Lava International plans to invest ₹1,100 crore over the next 5 years to diversify its presence in the electronics components ecosystem, a senior company official said on Thursday. The company has established a new mobile charger facility as part of its diversification.

LIC Q4 net jumps 23% on higher premium income, declares 1:1 bonus

GOOD SHOW. Income from investment increases to ₹109,211 crore, AUM up 5% to ₹57.3 lakh crore

Our Bureau Mumbai

The Life Insurance Corporation of India has registered a 23 per cent increase in net profit in the March quarter at ₹23,467 crore against ₹19,039 crore logged in the same period last year.

The insurance behemoth also announced a 1-for-1 bonus issue of shares, as well as a pre-bonus dividend of ₹10 per share.

HIGH POINTS

LIC registered 12 per cent jump in premium income of ₹165,067 crore (₹147,917 crore) with new business premium income increasing 17 per cent to ₹13,009 crore (₹11,103 crore).

Renewal and single

premium income jumped to ₹82,233 crore (₹79,425 crore) and ₹70,119 crore (₹57,694 crore). Income from investment also increased to ₹109,211 crore (₹93,443 crore).

The company's solvency ratio improved to 2.35 per cent during the quarter, up from 2.11 per cent a year ago and 2.19 per cent in the previous quarter.

However, LIC's 13th month persistency ratio stood lower at 67.77 per cent against 68.62 per cent in the year-ago period and 69.36 per cent in the December quarter.

Assets under management rose 5 per cent y-o-y to ₹57.3 lakh crore, while the value of new business surged 42 per cent to ₹14,179 crore during the quarter, indicating im-

Scorecard

	Q4 FY25	Q4 FY26
Income (₹ lakh cr)	2.42	2.77
Net profit (₹ cr)	19,039	23,467
EPS (Diluted) (₹)	30.10	37.10

proved profitability in fresh business generation.

The insurer has been working on improving margins and increasing its share of non-participating products to enhance earnings quality.

BIG GAINS

In FY26, LIC has registered the highest-ever profit of ₹57,453 crore (₹48,320 crore) and premium income

In FY26, LIC registered the highest-ever profit of ₹57,453 crore and premium income of ₹5,37,604 crore

of ₹5,37,604 crore (₹4,89,775 crore).

R Doraiswamy, CEO & MD, LIC, said the strategy of channel diversification had been successful with the Banca and Alternate Channels having recorded a growth rate of over 45 per cent with premium from BAC exceeding ₹5,000 crore in FY26.

“With regulatory guidance, we are preparing to im-

plement the Indian Accounting Standards norms and are confident about implementing within allowed regulatory time frames,” he said.

ROAD AHEAD

On emerging competition from foreign players, he said new players were bound to enter a vibrant market such as India and being a market leader, LIC will attempt to protect its market share, but every policy being added by the new players will eat into the market share of the existing players.

“As the insurance company navigates the markets, as the leading life insurance company, LIC remains immensely grateful to almost 200 million policyholders for their continued trust spanning seven decades,” he said.

Organised FMCG players eye 8-10% revenue growth in FY27: Crisil report

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani New Delhi

The organised fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) sector is expected to post 8-10 per cent revenue growth this fiscal as players begin passing on the impact of crude-linked inputs, including packaging materials, emanating from the West Asia conflict, according to estimates by Crisil Ratings. It noted this will be a tad higher than about 8 per cent witnessed in FY26.

While there will be a 6-7 per cent increase in realisations as players partially pass on the increase in prices of crude-linked inputs, the volume growth is likely to moderate to 2-3 per cent this fiscal amidst inflationary pressures. In FY26, organised FMCG players witnessed 5-6 per cent volume growth.

“Consequently, the earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation margin of our rated FMCG players is seen declining 150-200 basis points (bps) this fiscal from about 19 per cent in fiscal 2026,” Crisil Ratings added.

The estimates are based on a study of 74 FMCG companies, accounting for a third of the sector's estimated ₹6.6 lakh crore revenue in fiscal 2026.

INFLATION IMPACT

Anuj Sethi, Senior Director, Crisil Ratings, said, “Household budgets, both rural and urban, will face inflationary headwinds this fiscal as average crude oil prices for this fiscal are projected at 30-35 per cent, higher on-year. Nevertheless, continuing benefits of the goods and services tax rationalisation undertaken in September 2025, along with increased allocation to welfare schemes, will provide some demand support for the sector.”

Cost pressures are not uniform across segments. Personal care and home care categories are facing a sharper increase in input prices compared to F&B.

Aditya Jhaver, Director, Crisil Ratings, said: “In the milieu, companies are calibrating their advertising spends, focusing on cost efficiencies and negotiating with suppliers and distributors across the value chain.”

GreenLine pushes for LNG in freight sector as fuel concerns rise

Rishi Ranjan Kala New Delhi

The conflict in West Asia has again highlighted India's dependence on diesel imports and the need to scale up various energy options to balance risks. Against this backdrop, LNG is emerging as a near-term bridge fuel for long-haul trucking and a transitional option for heavy-duty transport.

The logistics sector, which contributes nearly 12 per cent to the GDP, remains heavily reliant on around 4 million diesel trucks that account for nearly 70 per cent of freight movement, making it a major source of fuel import dependence. With freight demand expected to double over the next five to

seven years, alternative fuels are gaining relevance. Diesel accounts for over 40 per cent of India's refined products demand.

“India's freight sector will require a robust multi-fuel infrastructure backbone to reduce dependence on imported crude and its products like diesel and ensure energy security. This includes a nationwide network of LNG refuelling stations alongside integrated capabilities for electric vehicle charging and battery swapping. Our focus is on developing this infrastructure along key freight corridors to support the transition in commercial transport,” Maqsood Shaikh, MD & CEO of Ultra Gas & Energy, told *businessline*.

Ultra Gas & Energy (UGEL), an Essar Group



MUTUAL WINS. Replacing just 10% of India's diesel trucking fleet with LNG could potentially save nearly \$3 billion annually in foreign exchange outflows

venture, is building a pan-India network of green fuel hubs such as LNG stations catering to industries and transporters. It currently operates seven stations and plans to expand this to 100 stations over the coming years. Each hub is designed to be future-ready, with capabilities for EV charging and battery swapping.

Among corporate players

driving the shift towards LNG mobility, GreenLine Mobility has emerged as one of the largest LNG fleet operators in the country.

FUTURE FOR LOGISTICS

GreenLine also plans to scale up its fleet to 10,000 LNG-fired trucks over the next 3-4 years. To support this transition, its subsidiary UGEL is building out an LNG refuel-

ling network along key freight corridors.

Madhur Taneja, CEO of GreenLine Mobility, said “The freight transition in India will likely be driven by multiple technologies. LNG currently offers the closest operational and commercial equivalent to diesel for heavy-duty trucking, given its long driving range, payload efficiency and faster refuelling capability, while EVs are better suited for short-haul and urban operations at present.”

According to industry sources, LNG trucks can offer a driving range of up to 1,200 km on a single fill and reduce CO₂ emissions by up to 40 per cent compared with diesel, while also lowering particulate matter, Sox, NOx and CO emissions. Replacing

just 10 per cent of India's diesel trucking fleet with LNG could potentially save nearly \$3 billion annually in foreign exchange outflows.

LNG also provides a major strategic energy-security advantage over diesel because LNG can be sourced from a significantly wider and more diversified global supplier base.

This becomes more pertinent in the backdrop of the conflict in West Asia.

India has already made significant investments in gas infrastructure, such as laying over 24,000 km of gas pipeline infrastructure, expanding LNG terminal capacity and city gas distribution coverage extending to almost the entire country. This also sets the stage for a rapid expansion in LNG use.

Kearney counters alarm over rupee slide to ₹120-140

Amit Vijay Mohile Mumbai

Global consulting firm Kearney has pushed back against fears that the rupee could breach the ₹100-per-dollar mark and slide further to ₹120-140 as predicted by some market pundits.

Kearney's top management said India's structural growth drivers remain strong enough to absorb external shocks even as the West Asia crisis threatens to shave 1-1.5 percentage points off the country's GDP growth over the next six to nine months.

In an interview with *businessline* during Kearney's “100 Years of Impact” celebrations, Bob Willen, Global Managing Partner and Chairman; Shigeru Sekinada, APAC Chair; and Siddharth Jain, Managing Partner and Country Head of Kearney India, said the rupee's fall to around ₹97 against the US dollar had revived concerns over imported inflation and currency volatility.

Willen said the current geopolitical disruptions could shave about 1 per cent



Bob Willen, Global Managing Partner and Chairman, Kearney

off global GDP, while Jain estimated India's impact at 1-1.5 percentage points, significantly lower than some market fears.

He added that he did not expect the rupee to fall to “alarming levels”, noting that currency depreciation also improved export competitiveness.

However, the consulting firm believes India is entering a new investment cycle led by green energy, electronics manufacturing, data centres and infrastructure, sectors expected to strengthen domestic demand and attract long-term capital.

The executives argued that largescale industrial investment, Japanese capital inflows and policy support

place India in a stronger position than many emerging economies.

“India and Japan have strong complementarities in technology, manufacturing and talent, and that partnership will deepen further,” Sekinada said, adding that Japanese companies were increasingly looking at India as part of a broader supply-chain diversification beyond China.

RISKS TO ECONOMY

Jain warned that many companies were underestimating the broader economic risks. While businesses were focused on visible pressures such as raw material shortages and rising costs, he said second- and third-order effects, such as fertilizer shortages, food inflation and weaker middle-class consumption, could prove more damaging.

Kearney expects the Indian economy to face higher energy prices, inflationary pressure, softer discretionary demand and continued volatility in commodity and currency markets over the next six to nine months.

At the same time, the con-

sultancy remains optimistic about India's longer-term trajectory.

Willen said India had evolved beyond an outsourcing-led economy into a more diversified, infrastructure-driven market, while Jain pointed to early signs of a revival in private capital expenditure.

ENERGY, AI SHIFTS

Kearney believes the current crisis could accelerate India's push toward energy independence.

Jain said electrification, battery manufacturing, renewable energy, hydrogen and ethanol blending were likely to gain momentum, though diesel-heavy transport remains a challenge.

Artificial intelligence is the second major structural shift Kearney highlighted. Willen said AI tools were already capable of eliminating or reducing up to 50 per cent of coding work in some software development tasks.

Jain, however, argued that AI is more likely to transform business models than reduce sector revenues as companies sharply increase technology spending.

Nykaa surpasses \$1 billion revenue mark

Our Bureau Mumbai

FSN E-Commerce Ventures, the parent of Nykaa, reported a sharp rise in revenue and profitability for the quarter and year ended March 31, crossing the \$1 billion revenue milestone in FY26 as demand across its beauty and fashion businesses remained strong.

The company said consolidated revenue from operations rose 26 per cent year-on-year to ₹10,022 crore in FY26, while gross merchandise value (GMV) increased 28 per cent to ₹19,963 crore. EBITDA for the year climbed 59 per cent to ₹752 crore, with margins expanding to 7.5 per cent from 6 per cent a

year earlier. Net profit surged 183 per cent to ₹204 crore.

For the March quarter, revenue grew 28 per cent y-o-y to ₹2,648 crore, marking the company's strongest quarterly growth in the last 12 quarters. Quarterly EBITDA rose 67 per cent to ₹223 crore, while profit after tax jumped more than fourfold to ₹79 crore.

Executive Chairperson, Founder and CEO Falguni Nayar said the company crossing the \$1 billion revenue milestone marked a defining moment in Nykaa's 14-year journey and reflected strong consumer trust in the platform.

The beauty vertical remained the largest contributor to growth, with beauty



GMV rising 27 per cent to ₹14,954 crore in FY26.

The retailer continued to invest in AI-led personalisation tools, including a virtual skin analyser and recommendation systems.

Its owned brands portfolio, House of Nykaa, recorded an annualised GMV run-rate of ₹3,176 crore, up 49

per cent y-o-y, while Superstore by Nykaa, the company's B2B beauty distribution business, reported GMV of ₹1,187 crore, nearly four times its FY23 level.

Nykaa Fashion posted GMV growth of 30 per cent to ₹4,954 crore in FY26, aided by the addition of over 1,280 brands and strong growth in categories such as menswear, kidswear and home products.

The company also completed the acquisition of clean beauty brand Earth Rhythm during FY26 after acquiring the remaining 24 per cent stake.

Nykaa said geopolitical tensions had impacted its GCC operations, though the effect on overall business remained insignificant.

Enterprise Connect

HDFC Bank WhatsApp Chat Banking Crosses 1 Crore Unique Monthly Active Users Milestone

HDFC Bank's WhatsApp Chat Banking platform has crossed significant adoption milestones, with over 1 crore 30-day active users and 2 crore 90-day active users as on March 31, 2026. The platform now serves more than 4 crore registered customers, almost 40% of the Bank's customer base. Alongside user growth, transactions have increased by 20%, demonstrating deeper engagement.

Speaking about the milestone, Rajanish Parmanand Prabhu, Head – Payments and Digital Banking Channels, HDFC Bank, said: “Crossing the 1 crore unique monthly active users milestone is a significant moment in our digital journey. What began as a simple service interface has now evolved into a full-scale conversational banking ecosystem. Customers are increasingly choosing chat for both routine services and high-value transactions. Our focus remains on making banking more customer-centric, intuitive and accessible within the platforms customers use every day.”

Ravi Garg, Director, Business Messaging, Meta in India, said: “WhatsApp is transforming how businesses and customers interact with each other and get things done, and milestones such as this demonstrate how messaging can truly drive meaningful value and build better experiences. We are delighted to see that HDFC Bank is truly leveraging the power of WhatsApp to deliver convenient and secure banking experiences at scale.”

HDFC Bank plans to further expand its Chat Banking capabilities with new product lines, strengthening its aim to make Chat Banking one of the preferred self-service channels for customers.

Kristu Jayanti University hosts the 11th National Educators Summit on “Navadrishhti: Shaping Future-Ready Schools through Digital Leadership

Kristu Jayanti University Leadership Excellence Academy for Development Services (KJU-LEADS) and the Internal Quality Assurance Cell (IQAC) of Kristu Jayanti University inaugurated the 11th Edition of the National Educators Summit titled “Navadrishhti: Shaping Future-Ready Schools through Digital Leadership” on May 7, 2026. The three-day summit, was held from May 7 to 9, 2026, has brought together over 150 principals, educators, academicians, and school administrators from schools and PU colleges across the country to deliberate on innovative and future-oriented educational practices.

The Chief Guest, Srinivasan Desikan, Managing Director of Qualplayers, Bengaluru, addressed the gathering on the importance and responsibility of teachers in shaping future generations. He emphasized the significance of Neuro-Linguistic Programming (NLP) in the education system, describing it as a valuable approach to enhancing communication, improving learning experiences, and fostering personal development among learners and educators highlighting Collaborative Intelligence (CI).

Delivering the Presidential Address, Rev. Dr. Augustine George CMI, Vice Chancellor of the University, reflected on the institution's vision inspired by the ideals of St. Kuriakose Elias Chavara. He emphasized that institutional culture plays a crucial role in sustaining excellence and highlighted the contribution of academicians, administrators, and well-wishers in building strong and value-driven educational institutions.

DSPM's K. V. Pendharkar College (Autonomous), Dombivli Achieves Joint National Patent in Zoological Research



“Morphometric Analysis of Snails”. Snails, being soft-bodied organisms enclosed within calcareous shells, play a crucial role in maintaining ecological balance. As decomposers, they contribute to soil formation, aeration, and nutrient cycling, including carbon and nitrogen cycles. Their morphological diversity, particularly shell shape and size, is essential for species identification and biodiversity studies. During research on snail biodiversity in Pune District, challenges were encountered in accurately surveying and measuring external morphological characteristics. Addressing this need, Mr. Aniket Marathe, along with Dr. Sharad

Shikshan Prasarak Mandal's K. V. Pendharkar College of Arts, Science and Commerce (Autonomous), Dombivli, has achieved a significant milestone as its Research Centre in the Department of Zoology has been awarded a Joint National Patent on

Business Initiative

S. Mahajan (Research Supervisor & Head, Department of Zoology), Capt. Dr. Varsha Uttam Narwade, and Mr. Arjun Sudhir Shah, developed an innovative device for precise morphometric analysis of snails. The invention was filed with the Patent Office, Government of India, on 4th December 2024, and after due process of examination and publication, the patent has been officially granted on 9th April 2026. On this occasion, Mr. Marshal Lavangare, CEO, Dombivli Shikshan Prasarak Mandal, felicitated Dr. Sharad Mahajan and Capt. Dr. Varsha Narwade for their outstanding contribution to research and innovation. This achievement reflects the institution's strong commitment to research excellence, innovation, and meaningful scientific contribution in the field of biological sciences.

Symbiosis Skills and Professional University (SSPU), Pune Secures National Victory at IIT Bombay's e-Yantra

In a landmark achievement that reinforces its growing national reputation in advanced engineering and skill-based education, Symbiosis Skills and Professional University (SSPU) has secured First Place in the Krishi Drone Theme at the prestigious e-Yantra Robotics Competition (eYRC) 2026, organized by Indian Institute of Technology Bombay. This victory marks SSPU's third consecutive national-level triumph at one of India's most respected robotics and embedded systems competitions, further establishing the university as a leading institution for future-ready engineering education and innovation-driven learning. The winning team, comprising Mr. Ram Passi and Mr. Vedant Ravngan, third-year students from the School of Mechatronics Engineering, distinguished themselves among 562 teams from across the country. The achievement stands as a strong reflection of the visionary academic ecosystem nurtured under the leadership of Dr. Swati Mujumdar, Pro-Chancellor, SSPU, whose focus on experiential learning, innovation, and industry-aligned education continues to create transformative opportunities for students. The university also acknowledged the mentorship and guidance provided by Dr. Sanjeev Sharma, Director, School of Mechatronics Engineering, and Prof. Jahida Subhedar, SPOC – e-Yantra, along with the faculty members of the School of Mechatronics Engineering, whose continuous technical support and mentorship played a crucial role throughout the competition journey. The national victory further strengthens SSPU's standing as an emerging Center for excellence in robotics, automation, mechatronics, and intelligent systems, while reinforcing the university's mission of preparing globally competent engineers equipped for Industry 4.0 and next-generation technological challenges.

Mankind - Rajeev Juneja contributes ₹9.17 crore to National Defence Fund, marks continued support for Armed Forces

Rajeev Juneja, Vice Chairman and Managing Director of Mankind Pharma, has contributed ₹9,17,950 to the National Defence Fund, marking the first anniversary of Operation Sindoor and reaffirming his continued support for the Armed Forces.

The number 9 is a reference to the nine terror bases targeted during the operation, while the remaining digits are a reference to the birth date of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, making the contribution a deliberate and meaningful figure rather than a rounded sum. This marks the second consecutive year that Mr. Juneja has made a personal contribution towards supporting the Armed Forces. The decision, he noted, is rooted in the belief that such support should be consistent and not limited to moments of heightened public attention.

“In moments of crisis, we come together with a strong sense of intent. But as time passes, that intensity often fades. For the Armed Forces, however, the responsibility never changes. Their commitment is constant, regardless of public attention. This contribution is a small way of recognising that continuity. It is not meant to be a one-time gesture, but part of an ongoing effort to support those who serve the nation every day. I also believe that when it comes to the nation, sharing such actions can encourage wider participation. Collective effort creates far greater impact than individual intent.”

He added that his perspective is also shaped by personal history. His family was displaced during Partition, with roots in Bahawalpur, and the experience of loss and rebuilding has remained deeply ingrained in his worldview. This lived history continues to inform his emotional connection to the nation and its security forces, particularly in moments when the country confronts threats originating from the same region.

The contribution builds on a broader record of support during national crises. During the COVID-19 pandemic, Mankind Pharma extended financial and on-ground assistance to frontline workers and affected families, including long-term support initiatives.



QUICKLY.

Gold falls as dollar and yields climb



Gold eased on Thursday, pressured by a stronger US dollar and high treasury yields, while stagnant peace talks in the Middle East kept inflation concerns alive. Spot gold was down 0.6 per cent at \$4,517.94 per ounce, as of 1118 GMT. US gold futures for June delivery lost 0.4 per cent at \$4,518.70. Silver was down 1.4 per cent at \$74.96. REUTERS

Copper retreats on slow progress of US-Iran talks

London: Copper prices eased on concern over slow progress by the US and Iran in forging a peace deal. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME lost 0.9 per cent to \$13,535 a tonne by 1000 GMT. Aluminium added 0.9 per cent to \$3,656. LME nickel slipped by 0.5 per cent to \$18,830 and tin dropped 1.7 per cent to \$53,110. REUTERS

Crude oil rebounds on Iran peace deal uncertainty



London: Crude oil prices edged higher as investors monitored peace talks between the US and Iran, while supply tightness and US inventory drawdowns provided some support. Brent crude futures rose 40 cents to \$105.42 a barrel by 0809 GMT. US WTI futures were up 50 cents at \$98.76. REUTERS

2 of 3 key reservoirs have less than 40% water; level below 25% in the south

WATER STRESS. Storage in 166 major dams down to 33% of 183.565 BCM capacity; S-W Monsoon will play crucial role

Our Bureau
Chennai

Two of three major reservoirs in the country had storage level less than 40 per cent of their capacity, even as the overall level in 166 key dams dropped to 33 per cent this week, data from the Central Water Commission (CWC) showed.

In the southern region, storage dropped below 25 per cent with the reservoir level in Karnataka and Telangana, two key States for kharif crops, slipping below 20 per cent.

Though storage is higher than a year ago by 12 percentage points and 24 percentage points more than normal, it could turn out to be critical in view of the India Meteorological Department (IMD) predicting below-normal South-West Monsoon

rainfall this year. One of the major concerns is that the central and western regions, too, depend on the monsoon for a good kharif harvest.

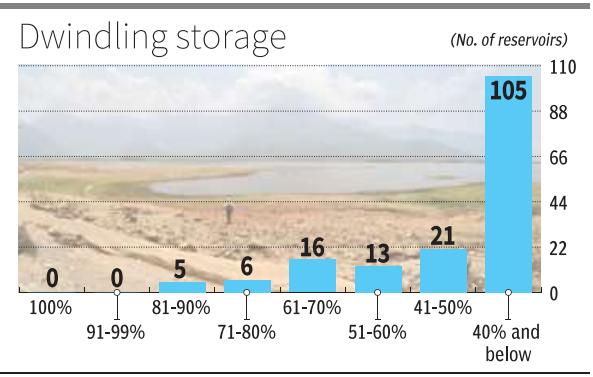
EL NINO THREAT

Any failure could affect key crops such as pulses, oilseeds and nutri-cereals. The northern region may not face problems as it gets irrigation water via canals.

In addition, various global weather agencies have predicted the emergence of the drought-bearing El Nino weather anytime from now, with some even saying that it could turn out to be a super El Nino.

CWC's weekly weather bulletin said that the level in the 166 major reservoirs was 60.830 billion cubic metres (BCM) of the 183.565 BCM capacity.

Of this, storage in 105 was less than 40 per cent, while in



Source: Central Water Commission

21, it was less than 50 per cent.

DEFICIENT RAIN

According to the IMD, 29 per cent of the 725 districts in the country received deficient rainfall between March 1 and May 20. During January-February, at least 70 per cent of the country received deficient or no rainfall.

The level in the 47 reservoirs in the southern region this week was 24.21 per cent of the 55.288 BCM capacity at 13.386 BCM. In Telangana and Karnataka, storage was 19 per cent each. In Andhra Pradesh, the level was 35 per cent, while in Tamil Nadu, it was 33 per cent. In Kerala, storage was 22 per cent.

The 28 reservoirs of the

central region, which had the highest storage this week, were filled to 39 per cent or 19.170 BCM of the 48.588 BCM capacity. In the eastern region, too, storage was a bit worrisome, with the level in the 27 reservoirs dropping to 27.5 per cent or 5.994 BCM of the 21.759 BCM capacity.

The level in West Bengal continued at 12.7 per cent.

PUNJAB BRIMS

The level in the 11 reservoirs of the northern region dropped to 40 per cent of the 19.836 BCM capacity at 7.932 BCM. Punjab had one of the highest levels in the country at 64 per cent, while it was 45 per cent in Rajasthan and 33 per cent in Himachal.

In the 53 reservoirs of the western region, storage was 37 per cent or 14.348 BCM of the 38.094 BCM capacity. Goa's lone reservoir was filled to 30 per cent capacity.

Wagh Bakri flags sharp fall in tea exports to W. Asia

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

Tea brand Wagh Bakri expects exports to West Asia to decline sharply this year as cargo delays of over 40-45 days, stranded shipments and weakening regional demand disrupt India's tea trade through the Strait of Hormuz, amid the ongoing geopolitical conflict.

"Exports to the Middle East have slowed considerably due to disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz. Our shipments are now delayed by over 40 days," Paras Desai, Executive Director of Gujarat Tea Processors and Packers Ltd, which sells un-



WANING EXPORTS. Nearly 60,000 kg of tea bound for Dubai was stranded at various ports, while cargo already in transit remained stuck for 45-60 days

der the Wagh Bakri brand, told *businessline*. Desai said nearly 60,000 kg

of tea bound for Dubai got stranded at various ports after the conflict escalated in

March-April, while cargoes already in transit remained stuck for 45-60 days. The company absorbed the additional logistics costs arising from the disruptions.

Sales in the region have already declined 10-15 per cent as hotels shut down, and the floating population of tourists and residents fell sharply amid the tensions.

"Exports to the Middle East are expected to dip significantly this year. We continue to receive orders from the region, but the core issue is logistics delays stretching up to 45 days," he said.

CLIMATE VOLATILITY

Wagh Bakri exports nearly 2.75 lakh kg of tea annually to

markets, including the UAE, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Bahrain and Saudi Arabia.

Apart from geopolitical disruptions, Desai said the tea industry is also grappling with rising production volatility due to erratic weather patterns and climate-related disruptions.

"Seasons have become highly unpredictable, and crop cycles are getting disrupted due to vagaries of nature," he said.

He added that in some months, production dropped to nearly 6 per cent of annual output against the expected 10-12 per cent, while in other months it surged to around 16 per cent, creating supply imbalances in the market.

Surat FPO turns cow dung-based bio-inputs into natural farming business

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Surat may be synonymous with diamonds and textiles, but a farmer producer organisation (FPO) based in Bardoli is trying to build a parallel identity for the district — as a hub for natural farming inputs.

PBM Surat SPNF Producer Company has quietly built a ₹2 crore business around 'Ghanjeevamrut', a microbial-rich bio-input increasingly being adopted by farmers who are moving away from chemical fertilizers. Led by Kamlesh Patel, the FPO now plans to expand into Patan and Surendranagar districts after demand surged over the past two years.

Patel told *businessline* that the FPO sold 90,000 bags of

Ghanjeevamrut last year and is targeting 1.3 lakh bags (of 40 kg each) this year. Though the company also markets liquid 'Jeevamrut' in 20-litre packs, volumes remain relatively small.

RIISING DEMAND

For farmers adopting natural farming, *Ghanjeevamrut* and *Jeevamrut* have emerged as alternatives to chemical fertilizers. Apart from supplying nutrients, the formulations are also seen as soil restorers because of their high microbial content.

Ghanjeevamrut is prepared by fermenting and drying a mixture of dung and urine from indigenous cattle breeds along with jaggery, gram flour and *mahua* flowers.

The formulation is rich in microbes that help unlock nutrients such as nitrogen,

phosphorus, calcium and micronutrients in the soil. *Jeevamrut*, its liquid variant, is known to improve earthworm activity and soil biology.

Patel said maintaining production quality remains labour-intensive. "Though the FPO has the capacity to produce 800-1,000 bags a day, output sometimes gets hampered when labourers do not turn up," he said.

LOWER INPUT COSTS

Despite having around 750 farmer-members, the FPO sources most of its raw material requirements from a single *gaushala* housing over 4,000 cows. Patel said cow dung is procured at ₹1.5 per kg, while *Jeevamrut* is sold at ₹100 for a 20-litre pack and *Ghanjeevamrut* at ₹240 for a 40-kg bag.

Among the adopters is

farmer Patel Fenilkumar Jayesh, who cultivated sugarcane and vegetables across 30 acres last year. Of the total area, 20 acres were under fully natural farming, while limited fertilizer use continued on the remaining land.

Farmers practising natural farming often acknowledge that yields may initially be slightly lower than under conventional cultivation. However, lower input costs and premium pricing for residue-free produce are increasingly improving farm economics.

Demand for such bio-inputs is also rising as the government sharpens its focus on natural farming. Till August 2025, 5.45 lakh hectares had been brought under the National Mission on Natural Farming, including 19,162 hectares in Gujarat.

FLAVOUR OF THE SEASON



PRICE SURGE. Vendors from Nalgonda district sell ice apples, popularly known as 'munjal', in Hyderabad. Retailing at ₹120 a dozen, vendors expect prices to rise further as palm trees are increasingly being cut down for commercial land use. RAMAKRISHNA G

New study highlights AI's potential to improve soil science

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

New research, led by Budi-man Minasnay and Alex McBratney, Professors from the University of Sydney Institute of Agriculture, has detailed how artificial intelligence (AI) tools can help us adapt soils — and the systems they nurture — to a changing climate.

Published by *Frontiers in Science*, the paper outlines how AI tools can accelerate soil science by speeding up early-stage work, improving predictions to support decisions on land use, carbon and climate adaptation, handling complex data and freeing scientists to focus on questions that require expert judgment.

Senior author McBratney said, "In partnership with ex-

perts, AI could help us better match the complexity and ever-changing nature of soil ecosystems. Unlike current machine learning tools that focus on isolated tasks, these systems can mimic scientific collaboration to a highly sophisticated degree, combining reasoning, planning and interdisciplinary insight to support researchers and drive significant progress."

AI AGENTS' HYPOTHESIS

Soil science currently uses machine learning approaches, such as digital soil mapping and spectroscopy. AI systems could enhance this by creating digital soil twins with data from sensors, enhancing soil microbiome monitoring and trailing climate adaptation strategies in computer models before testing them in the field for faster results.

To illustrate such a tool, the research team tasked a multi-agent AI system with reviewing relevant scientific literature and generating ideas about how soils store carbon and what controls their storage limits.

The paper said the AI agents successfully generated five hypotheses, including climate influence, saturation thresholds, biological and chemical controls, interdisciplinary feedback and management strategies.

Lead author Minasnay said, "Our findings indicate the opportunity for AI to accelerate soil research, the understanding of which can benefit our food and climate systems. Improving our understanding of soils could support more sustainable agriculture, better soil management and stronger climate adaptation."

Go long on lead futures at ₹203

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl.research bureau

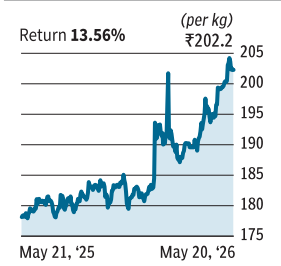
Lead futures (₹203/kg) have been appreciating steadily since the beginning of this year. Importantly, it broke out of the range of ₹173-196 last week. This is a significant move as this price band had shackled lead futures since July 2021.

COMMODITY CALL.

The breakout of ₹196 and the subsequent monthly close at ₹199.40 for April has given lead futures a marked shift in the trend.

The prevailing price action of May futures shows no sign of a bearish reversal. Although it marked a high of ₹205.50 on May 14 and has since seen some softening in price, the bull trend appears intact.

The nearest support is ₹201, where the 21-day mov-



ing average lies. Subsequent support levels are at ₹198 and ₹196. As long as these levels stay valid, the probability of further rally is high. We expect lead futures to touch ₹212 in the near-term.

If the contract faces a decline below ₹196, which is less likely to occur before lead futures rising to ₹212, the outlook could turn weak, possibly dragging the price lower to ₹190 and ₹186.

TRADE STRATEGY

Go long on lead futures now at ₹203. Target and stop-loss can be ₹212 and ₹199, respectively.

IPL Biologicals inaugurates first phase of ₹400 crore Gujarat facility

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

IPL Biologicals Ltd on Thursday inaugurated phase-I of its proposed ₹400 crore biological manufacturing facility in Vadodara as the company ramps up production of biofertilizers and biopesticides, amid a growing policy push to reduce chemical fertilizer usage.

The first phase of the project, built on an investment of around ₹200 crore, has commissioned a 50 kilolitres (KL) per day production facility, which will primarily manufacture biofertilizers and biopesticides.

The company plans to double capacity to 100 KL per day under phase-II.

"In phase-I, a 50 KL per day facility for biofertilizers and biopesticides has been commissioned. Roughly 60

IIRR's direct seeded rice initiative raises yields by 8-13%, cuts costs by 21%

KV Kurmanath
Hyderabad

A direct seeded rice (DSR) initiative by the Indian Institute of Rice Research (IIRR), an Indian Council of Agricultural Research agency, in partnership with the SBI Foundation, has shown that yields can rise 8-13 per cent over conventional transplanted cultivation across seasons. The project also demonstrated a 21-23 per cent reduction in cultivation costs per acre, leading to higher net returns for farmers.

Using internet of things (IoT)-based sensors, farmers were also able to cut water use by 25-35 per cent. "This has proved the viability of DSR cultivation, compared to the water-intensive traditional method," an IIRR spokesperson said.

DSR is a cultivation method in which rice seeds are sown directly in the field, without raising nursery seedlings or carrying out manual transplantation.

Encouraged by the results, the area under DSR cultivation in the project villages expanded by 5,947 acres within a year, generating an estimated additional economic benefit of about ₹7.73 crore for farmers.

HIGHER ADOPTION

"The rapid increase in DSR adoption reflects growing farmer confidence in climate-resilient and water-saving rice production technologies," the spokesperson said.

The IIRR initiative, supported financially by the SBI Foundation, was implemented during 2024-26 in the undivided Nalgonda and Khammam districts of Telangana. The programme combined scientific research, precision agriculture technologies, mechanisation



and intensive farmer outreach.

Rice is cultivated on nearly 47 million hectares in India, producing over 140 million tonnes annually. Telangana has emerged as one of the leading producers, with over 4.6 million hectares under cultivation and an output of 17 million tonnes. "Rice cultivation is increasingly facing challenges, such as rising input costs, excessive water consumption, labour shortages, delayed transplanting operations and greenhouse gas emissions associated with conventional transplanted systems," the spokesperson said.

This has created an urgent need for sustainable and resource-efficient alternatives in rice production. The institute launched the DSR initiative to address these challenges.

COST CUTTING

The programme initially covered 1,000 farmers across 20 selected villages in the two districts. DSR is practised in two forms — dry DSR, where seeds are sown in dry soil using tractor-operated seed drills before the monsoon, and wet DSR, where sprouted seeds are broadcast manually or sown using drum seeders in wet fields. The method requires fewer seeds and significantly reduces labour and water use. Farmers also harvest the crop nearly 10 days early, enabling quicker turnaround for the next crop cycle.

QUICKLY.

RP Defense bags ₹29.8 cr order for rifle scopes

New Delhi: RRP Defense has secured a ₹29.8 crore order from Bharat Electronics Ltd to supply high-precision germanium lenses used in infrared and thermal imaging applications to be mounted on rifles used by the armed forces. Rajendra Chodankar, Founder & Chairman, RRP Group of Companies, told *businessline*, “The company will build 10 samples in four-six weeks and once they are tested and accepted by the BEL, the supply of 8,000 sets of 23 mm and 47 mm diameter optical elements will be executed.” **OUR BUREAU**

IRDAI offers two-month project-based internships

Hyderabad: The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India is offering a two-month project-based internship for graduates and postgraduates and for final year students. It will be offered to 15 selected candidates at IRDAI's head office in Hyderabad from June. The interns will be paid a stipend of ₹15,000 per month. Candidates pursuing insurance, law, management, economics or IT will be preferred. **OUR BUREAU**

‘To be \$5 trillion economy, UP targets to be a global hub for data centres: CM

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The Uttar Pradesh Data Centre Cluster is a long-term strategy to make the State the biggest artificial intelligence (AI) compute power centre in the country and the Global South, Yogi Adityanath said, adding that the project can begin from the Bundelkhand Industrial Development Authority (BIDA) area, where large-scale land is available. He added that dialogue should be established with major tech companies, in-



The State will generate more than 1.5 lakh direct jobs and develop a 5-GW AI compute corridor by 2040

YOGI ADITYANATH
Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

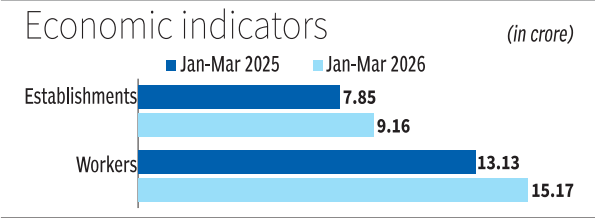
cluding the Tata Group, to develop Lucknow as an ‘AI City’. Earlier this year, the UP government announced plans to develop eight data



centre parks across the State, with the initiative expected to attract an investment of around ₹2 lakh crore and generate over 50,000 direct jobs.

Reviewing the Uttar Pradesh Data Centre Cluster (UPDCC), the Chief Minister said that the project will create the basic infra for UP's AI mission. “The Data Centre Cluster should not remain limited to the NCR region and other parts of the State should also be connected with it,” Adityanath said.

AI PUSH This is one of the targets to build UP a \$5 trillion economy, generate more than 1.5 lakh direct jobs and develop a 5-GW AI compute corridor by 2040. The



per cent over the corresponding quarter of the previous year, highlighting its growing significance in generating employment opportunities for a large section of the population across sectors.

Working owners continued to account for the largest share of the workforce in the unincorporated sector, constituting 60.97 per cent of total workers, compared to 58.29 per cent in the corresponding quarter of the previous year.

In contrast, the share of hired workers witnessed a marginal decline, falling to 24.77 per cent from 26.86 per cent.

RURAL EMPLOYMENT The growing importance of unincorporated enterprises in supporting the rural economy was further reflected in the robust growth of the rural workforce, which recorded an increase of 21.65 per cent during the period, compared to 10.39 per cent growth in the urban sector.

“Many unincorporated units depend on casual labour, migrant workers and helpers who often shift to seasonal agricultural work and return either as an entrepreneur or as a worker when activity in the sector strengthens, leading to a rise in employment and establishments,” it said.

world's new economy will develop around ‘future arenas’ such as AI, cloud, cyber security, semiconductors, electric vehicles, robotics and space technology, whose combined global market could reach \$29-48 trillion, he said.

Adityanath described UP as Asia's most secure, scalable and connected inland AI territory. Almost all major fibre networks in the country pass through UP, and the State is connected to all of India's sea cable landing points.

Connectivity of less than 5 milliseconds within the

State and 5-12 milliseconds connectivity to digital hubs like Mumbai and Chennai is available. For global tech companies, UP is an ideal AI infrastructure hub with lower costs, better scalability, and higher network redundancy, he added.

TALENT PIPELINE In terms of talent, he added that, due to the Indian Institute of Technology Kanpur, the National Institute of Technology Prayagraj, and more than 50 engineering institutions, the State has a large pool of technical talent.

TN expands Cabinet with 23 new Ministers, including two from Cong



EXPANDING TEAM. Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar with S Kamali (left) and K Jagadeshwari in the presence of Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay **BUJOY GHOSH**

Our Bureau
Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph C Vijay on Thursday expanded his Cabinet by inducting 23 Ministers, including two from the Congress and 21 from his Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK).

This takes the total size of the Ministry to 33, including Vijay.

The swearing-in ceremony was held at the Lok Bhavan in the presence of political leaders and party representatives. Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar administered the oath of office and secrecy to the newly inducted Ministers.

Of the 23 members inducted into the Cabinet, three are women: Kamali from the Avinashi constituency, C Vijayalakshmi from Kumarapalayam and Jagadeshwari from Rajapalayam.

Other Ministers inducted from the TVK are Srinath, RV Ranjithkumar, Vinoth, Rajeev, B Rajkumar, V Gandhiraj, Mathan Raja, M Vijay Balaji, Logesh Tamilselvan D, Vijay Tamilan Parthiban, Ramesh, Kumar R, Thennarasu K, V Sampath Kumar, Mohamed Farvas J, D Sarathkumar, N Marie Wilson and K Vignesh.

Leaders from the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Kathi (VCK), the Communist parties, and senior Congress leader Girish Chodankar attended the event.

Following the swearing-in, the State government also

shuffled the portfolios of some Ministers.

FINANCE PORTFOLIO One of the senior-most members and 11-time MLA, KA Sengottaiyan, who was given the Finance portfolio, was instead given Revenue and Disaster Management.

Finance went to Marie Wilson of Radhakrishna Nagar constituency.

Srinath, MLA from Thoothukudi, is the Minister for Fisheries and Fishermen Welfare. Vinoth of Kumbakonam is Minister for Agriculture-Farmers Welfare. Mathan Raja P is the MSME Minister.

Ramesh, who was elected from the Srirangam constituency, has been appointed as the Minister for the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments (HR&CE) Department. In a first for Tamil Nadu, the government has renamed the IT Ministry as Artificial Intelligence, Information Technology & Digital Services Ministry, with R Kumar of Velachery handed this portfolio.

CONG PARTICIPATION The Cabinet expansion is being viewed as a significant milestone for the Congress party in Tamil Nadu. With the induction of MLAs Rajesh Kumar (Killyoor) and P Viswanathan (Melur), the party has secured representation in the State Cabinet after a gap of nearly six decades.

With inputs from intern
G Mahalakshmi

Navy to acquire 45 ships in 3-4 years, gets nod for 195 more: Vice Admiral Vatsyan

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Navy plans to acquire 45 ships in 3 to 4 years as it pushes to reach the much-needed fleet strength of at least 200 vessels by 2035.

The Navy has 45 ships under various stages of construction in India for delivery over the next 3-4 years, Navy Vice Chief Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsyan said on Wednesday after the launch of *Sanghamitra*, the first of four next-generation offshore patrol vessels (NGOPVs) being built by the defence PSU Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers (GRSE) Ltd.

Vice Admiral Vatsyan stated, “We have got acceptance of necessity (nod) for another 69 ships, six submarines and 120 fast interceptor craft.”

“There is a very big opportunity for the entire defence



Vice Chief of the Naval Staff Vice Admiral Sanjay Vatsyan and Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers Chairman and MD Com (ret'd) PR Hari (left) at the launch ceremony **PTI**

building ecosystem to deliver quality products in time with the capabilities required by the Navy,” he added.

The Ministry of Defence is actively pursuing to become *aatmanirbhar* in the production of naval ships for securing the Indo-Pacific and transition into a dominant-blue-water Navy.

By 2030, the Navy wants to increase its fleet strength to at least 155 to 160 from the existing about 130-odd vessels. In the next five years, the Navy wants to become a 200-ship maritime force.

DOMINANT FORCE Vice Admiral Vatsyan said the Navy had evolved into a

force committed not only to combat preparedness but also to maintaining a stable maritime environment through cooperation, presence and operational readiness.

“In this broader context, the next-generation offshore patrol vessel project holds considerable significance,” he said.

The GRSE delivered eight ships to the Navy during the last financial year. The NGOPVs are significantly larger and more capable than conventional offshore patrol vessels, with enhanced endurance and firepower, officials said.

The vessel measures around 113 m in length and 14.6 m in width, with a displacement of 3,000 tonnes, they said. The ship, they added, has an endurance of 8,500 nautical miles at a cruising speed of 14 knots and can achieve a maximum speed of 23 knots.

Our Bureau
Kochi

As the new United Democratic Front (UDF) government settles into office, Kerala's technology and start-up ecosystem is looking beyond incremental expansion and pushing for a larger structural transformation of the innovation economy.

Industry leaders across the spectrum say Kerala has an opportunity to reposition itself as a stronger technology destination by addressing long-standing concerns related to infrastructure, ease of doing business, transport connectivity, commercial space and industry-academia collaboration.

Despite the steady growth of technology hubs such as Kochi and Thiruvananthapuram, cities like Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Pune manage to attract

For many in the sector, the core challenge is no longer talent availability but the creation of an ecosystem

global technology investments. Kerala has evolved into a talent-rich but opportunity-constrained ecosystem, forcing many professionals to migrate outside the State for career growth.

CORE CHALLENGE For many in the sector, the core challenge is no longer talent availability but the creation of an ecosystem capable of retaining skilled professionals while simultaneously attracting largescale investments.

V Sreekumar, Secretary of the Group of Technology

Companies and Centre Head at Tata Elxsi, said the government must prioritise infrastructure, branding, skill development and policy support while accelerating ease-of-doing-business reforms. He called for regular IT and industry expos across Thiruvananthapuram, Kochi and Kozhikode to strengthen collaboration opportunities among companies operating in the State.

He proposed the creation of a nodal agency that would integrate sectors such as IT, electronics, artificial intelligence, semiconductors and space technology.

Deepa Sarojammal, Executive Chairperson of Reflections, said, “Kerala has never lacked talent; some of the best technology professionals in the world come from here. But for years, many young people have looked beyond the State in search of larger opportunities and

faster-growing tech ecosystems.”

EMERGING SECTORS Beyond traditional IT services, emerging sectors such as deeptech and space tech are increasingly becoming central to Kerala's technology ambitions.

Aravind MB, COO of HEX20, said space technology holds long-term economic potential for Kerala.

According to industry projections, the sector could grow into a \$44 billion market with a CAGR of 20-25 per cent over the next eight years, offering substantial opportunities for the State if it can capture even a fraction of that growth.

Vineeth Chandran, Secretary of Prathidhwani Technopark, said the IT employee community expects the government to enable transport connectivity and employee welfare.

Align Technology to invest ₹1,800 crore in Telangana

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Global dental player Align Technology will invest ₹1,800 crore in Telangana to set up the company's first manufacturing site in India.

This unit will be the fourth for Align Technology globally, and will create more than 300 direct jobs over the next several years. It will start production in 2027.

A MoU in this regard was signed by Jitse Marree, Senior Vice-President, Align Technology, and Sarvesh Singh, CEO, Telangana Life Sciences, according to a release.

CAPACITY ADDITION The production facility with largescale 3D printing and

sophisticated digital technologies will add to the company's worldwide production capacity of nearly 10 lakh unique clear aligner parts per day.

“Align Technology's decision to plan its India manufacturing presence in Telangana reflects the growing global confidence in our state's strengths across medTech, life sciences, precision manufacturing, and healthcare innovation,” Duddilla Sridhar Babu, Telangana Minister for Information Technology, Electronics, Communications, Industries & Commerce, and Legislative Affairs, said in a release on Thursday.

Align Technology has its GCC, the Align Innovation Centre, in Hyderabad.

Paradise Biryani to invest ₹100 cr to open 100 outlets

Samar Capital targets ₹550 crore turnover through aggressive expansion

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Paradise Biryani, a popular biryani brand in Hyderabad, is going places. After acquiring it from its promoters, Samar Capital has said it will invest ₹100 crore to establish a pan-India presence and open 100 outlets across major cities.

“After the expansion, we would have 150 stores and a turnover of ₹550 crore. We are currently at an annual revenue run rate of about ₹300 crore,” Abhik Mitra, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of Paradise Food Court Pvt Ltd, told *businessline*.

“We are looking at scaling Paradise into a future-



SPICING IT UP. The investment will enable a nationwide rollout while preserving the brand's Hyderabad legacy **DEEPAK KR**

ready national food brand while continuing to preserve the authenticity and legacy associated with Hyderabad's culinary identity,” he said.

“We are focusing on new stores in Bengaluru and Chennai, where we are already present. We are also looking at Mumbai, NCR and Pune. In Bengaluru and

Chennai, the total biryani consumption is equal to the Hyderabad consumption,” he said.

CONSUMER BEHAVIOUR Nilay Pratik, Managing Director, Samara Capital, said the organised food services sector was witnessing strong structural growth, driven by changing consumer behaviour, rising disposable incomes, and increasing preference for trusted brands.

“What appealed to us was the strength of Paradise as a brand and the long-term opportunity it holds within this space. The company has all pillars of scalability now firmly in place,” he said.

RIL, partners refute in SC Centre's claim of ‘unjust’ gas extraction from ONGC field

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL) on Thursday strongly refuted in the Supreme Court the Centre's claim that the company and its two offshore partner firms allegedly siphoned from the K-G basin deposits gas which migrated to their area from the state-owned ONGC gas field.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi was hearing the appeals of RIL, BP Exploration (Alpha) Ltd and Niko (NECO) Ltd against a Delhi High Court verdict of February 14, 2025, setting aside an arbitral award in their favour in the gas migration dispute with the Centre.

The Oil Ministry on November 4, 2016, slapped a demand of \$1.47 billion on the Reliance-BP-Niko combine for the gas.

Senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for RIL, maintained, “The gas may have migrated because of pressure difference.”

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thehindu **businessline**.
A CH-CE

QUICKLY.

Anthropic in talks to use Microsoft's AI chips



Anthropic is in talks to rent servers powered by Microsoft's AI chips for complex workloads, *The Information* reported on Thursday. The tech giant's shares were up about 1.5 per cent in premarket trading. A partnership between the two companies would mark a significant win for Microsoft, which is seeking to emulate rivals Alphabet and Amazon by developing an alternative to Nvidia chips that dominate AI workloads. The Claude-maker's talks to rent Microsoft's chips are still early and may not lead to a deal. **REUTERS**

Sakar Healthcare in pact with Zydus Lifesciences



Mumbai: Sakar Healthcare, a manufacturer and exporter specialising in oncology, antibiotics and general formulations, has signed a deal with Zydus Lifesciences to supply oncology products across GCC countries and other emerging markets. The company has so far signed 40 agreements in the anti-cancer segment globally. Sakar Healthcare has submitted 33 site variations across key partners, including Accord Healthcare in the UK, Heumann Pharma GmbH & Co Generica KG in Germany and Torrent Pharma and Tillomed Laboratories in the UK. **OUR BUREAU**

Novo Nordisk unveils higher dose Wegovy for enhanced weight loss

SLIM AND TRIM. Early responders will get up to 28% weight loss with the high dose: Novo Nordisk Executive V-P

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai



Launching our high doses is a priority across all geographies

EMIL KONGSHØJ LARSEN
Executive Vice-President
(International Operations)



A new and higher dose of obesity drug Wegovy has joined Novo Nordisk's semaglutide portfolio, giving patients and doctors more options for treatment. This comes even as semaglutide — the active ingredient in weight loss drug Wegovy and diabetes drug Ozempic — begins to face generic competitors in countries, including India. The Danish healthcare company has plans to bring the higher dose to India, said company executives.

"There's no one size that fits all for obesity patients. They come in many shapes and forms and have each of their challenges... The high dose Wegovy (7.2 mg) offering that we are launching across Europe soon and the United Kingdom... is important for patients because some will need bigger weight loss than what we have seen so far," Emil Kongshøj Larsen, Novo Nordisk's Executive Vice-President (In-

ternational Operations), told *businessline*.

He was speaking from Istanbul, where Novo Nordisk presented its new analysis at the recent European Congress on Obesity, indicating that a higher dose of Wegovy was effective in helping people lose significant amount of weight.

WEGOVY PILL

Citing data presented at the Congress, Larsen said: "Early responders will actually get up to 28 per cent weight loss with the high dose Wegovy... But some patients prefer all offerings and formats. And that's why we're also excited to launch new data on the Wegovy pill,

also showing that early responders can go as high as having 22 per cent weight loss."

The average weight loss seen in trials is 17 per cent, the highest of any oral medicine out there for obesity, he said.

Another insight from the data pointed to concerns on muscle mass or lean body mass in patients who have overall weight loss, he said.

Data from their Step-Up clinical trial showed that a vast majority of the weight loss from a high dose of Wegovy was from pure fat.

This indicated that patients retained their strength and mobility as they lose weight, he explained.

"We're giving more and more good reasons to actually start the weight loss journey if you are a patient that's overweight or obese, and particularly if you have comorbidities," said Larsen.

INDIA TIMELINE

On the company's plan for India, Larsen said: "Launching our high doses is a priority across all geographies."

Industry data pegs semaglutide's annual sales, across the pill and injectable formats, at about \$33 billion.

Vikrant Shrotriya, Novo Nordisk (India) Managing Director, said that the company will approach the Indian drug regulator to seek approvals for the 7.2 mg dosage.

While they are yet to submit applications, he said that there was much opportunity still to be tapped in the dose strengths already available in India.

"Patients will have a very good experience... for the first year with the doses now available in India. And then some patients will need to over time titrate to a higher

dose... The current formats [of] Wegovy and the strengths will go a very long way in India," he said.

GENERIC VERSIONS

Wegovy's journey in India has been punctuated with price cuts and partnerships, as it faces domestic drug-makers launching their generic versions of this drug at 50-80 per cent of the innovators original price.

"The story we've seen so far in India, I think, is very encouraging because ... GLP-1 (the class semaglutide belongs to) is being talked about by more companies because the benefits are so unique... Treatment volumes are going up many fold in just a matter of a month or two," said Larsen.

"We actually have the opportunity to win in this very, very competitive market as the originator company when it comes to Wegovy and Ozempic and our brands are doing better than ever. So, it is an expanding market because many more patients get to benefit from semaglutide."

India, African Union postpone summit amid Ebola outbreak

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

India and the African Union have postponed their summit meeting scheduled next week in New Delhi following the deadly outbreak of Ebola virus in the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) and its international spread.

"Recognising the importance of ensuring the full participation and engagement of African leaders and stakeholders, and mindful of the emerging public health situation on the continent, the two sides agreed that it would be advisable to convene the Fourth India-Africa Forum Summit at a later date," said the Ministry of External Affairs in a statement issued on Thursday.

India reaffirmed its solidarity with the people and governments of Africa and expressed its readiness to contribute to Africa CDC-led efforts aimed at addressing the evolving health situation, in line with the shared commitment to an Africa-led response, the statement added.

Ebola is a deadly disease caused by a group of viruses known as orthoebolaviruses, commonly affecting humans and non-human primates such as monkeys, chimpanzees and gorillas.

On May 15, Ebola outbreak was confirmed by the Ministry of Health of the DRC in Ituri province in the northeastern part of the country.

CONFIRMED CASES

The WHO, on May 17, noted that the international spread had already been documented, with two confirmed cases reported in Kampala, Uganda, following travel from the DRC.

The 17th outbreak of the

Ebola virus in DRC is suspected to have infected 600 people and caused 139 deaths.

Ebola advisory for travellers from high-risk regions

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

Against the backdrop of the Ebola virus initially reported from the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) and now spreading to countries in the region, India's Directorate General of Health Services has put out an advisory for passengers travelling from the region.

Passengers travelling from or through high-risk regions, including DRC, Uganda and South Sudan, who exhibit symptoms such as fever, headache and unexpected bleeding, or those who have had contact with bodily fluids of people suspected of having Ebola, are required to contact the airport health officer or health desk before immigration clearance, said the DGHS under the Union Health Ministry.

Travellers presenting with symptoms within 21 days of travel also need to alert health authorities, said the advisory.

The passenger advisory was shared by Delhi airport, and it is expected that similar screening will come up at other ports as well.

Meanwhile, Health Ministry sources said no cases of Ebola had been reported in India, and that the country had activated its surveillance mechanisms.

Eli Lilly says its obesity drug helps patients lose 28% weight

Reuters
New York

Eli Lilly said on Thursday that its experimental drug Retatrutide helped patients diagnosed with obesity lose more than 28 per cent of their weight over a year-and-a-half in a key trial that helps pave the way for the firm to seek regulatory approval and launch the drug next year.

Shares of Lilly climbed 1 per cent in premarket trading.

The late-stage trial, which tracked weight loss in patients diagnosed with obesity but not diabetes, marks the latest leg of Lilly's push to dominate the booming market for obesity medications, such as its injectable Zepbound and Novo Nordisk's Wegovy.

This is Lilly's most powerful weight loss drug yet, and

is meant to appeal to those who need to lose the most weight.

TRIPLE G EFFECT

Retatrutide is the first of Lilly's obesity drugs that activates three hormone receptors — GLP-1 to suppress appetite, GIP to enhance insulin secretion and glucagon to aid fat burning — earning it the nickname "triple G".

In previous trials, it has

been shown to boost weight loss well beyond Lilly's and its Danish rival's other drugs.

LATE-STAGE TRIAL

In this late-stage trial for adults with obesity or who were overweight and at least one weight-related comorbidity, the firm found patients on the highest dose, 12 mg, of retatrutide lost an average of 28.3 per cent of their weight over 80 weeks. More

than 45 per cent of participants lost 30 per cent or more.

"That's really a threshold that's historically been associated with bariatric surgery," said Kenneth Custer, Eli Lilly's President of Cardiometabolic Health. "To have that available in a medicine is a pretty big deal."

Custer said the company hopes to launch the drug next year.

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